

Shiv Nadar University workers protest, demand salary hike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

Hundreds of men and women workers at Shiv Nadar University in Greater Noida's Dadri area staged a sit-in protest on Wednesday morning, demanding a substantial salary hike and doubling of overtime payments. The demonstrators squatted on the road outside the university's main entrance gate, raising slogans to press their demands.

However, Gautam Buddh Nagar police officials confirmed that the situation remained entirely peaceful and was swiftly brought under control following constructive talks with the protesters.

The protest erupted around early morning as contractual and support staff gathered in large numbers, highlighting long-standing grievances over compensation. Key demands included an immediate increase in

base salaries and enhanced overtime rates, alongside other unspecified issues related to working conditions.

However, by 10:45 AM, the demonstration ended as the senior police officials spoke to the protesters, and they agreed to the suggestions given by the district administration. A senior police official stated, "The situation remained peaceful and normalcy was restored after discussions with the workers. There is no ongoing protest at the site." Authorities praised the restraint shown by both sides, emphasising dialogue as the key to resolution. No arrests or disruptions to university operations were reported, and traffic movement in the Dadri area returned to normal shortly afterwards.

This incident at the private university comes against the backdrop of simmering labour unrest across Noida and Greater Noida. Just days



earlier, on April 13-14, large-scale protests by factory workers in Noida's industrial hubs, including Phase-2 and the Hosiyari Complex, turned violent. Demands for higher wages, timely payments, bonuses, and overtime compensation led to clashes, stone-pelting, arson, and vandalism. Over 300 individuals were arrested, and seven FIRs were registered in connection with these events.

Taking pre-emptive measures, the Gautam Buddha Nagar Police intensified security measures on Wednesday. Additional Police Commissioner, Law and Order, Rajiv Narayan Mishra, along with senior officers, conducted flag marches and foot patrols in sensitive areas.

Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police Manisha Singh led similar exercises in the Phase-1 police

station area, coordinating with local teams and even Delhi Police personnel. Officials directed continuous patrolling by PCR and PRV vehicles, urging field units to take strict action against any attempts to disturb peace or spread rumours.

Manisha Singh appealed to the public for cooperation, warning of legal consequences for those disrupting law and order.

District Magistrate Medha Roopam, in a high-level review meeting, issued stern warnings to outsourcing agencies and contractors. She cautioned against black-listing firms that breach regulations, emphasising direct bank transfers of minimum wages without deductions and the need for industrial harmony. Disruptions, she noted, harm workers, employers, and the local economy alike. A minor related protest by domestic help outside a premium high-rise society on Tuesday demanding salary hikes and additional leave further underscored the prevailing discontent.

As of late Wednesday afternoon, the Shiv Nadar University campus and surrounding areas reported complete calm, with no fresh incidents. University authorities have not issued an official statement on the workers' demands or ongoing negotiations.

FIR REGISTERED AGAINST TWO RJD SPOKESPERSONS IN NOIDA

Noida: In a fresh development amid the ongoing labour unrest in Noida, the Gautam Buddha Nagar cyber police station has registered an FIR against two national spokespersons of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), Priyanka Bharti and Dr Kanchana Yadav. The duo has been accused of sharing a misleading video on social media platform X, falsely linking it to the Noida workers' protests and allegedly inciting tension in the region.

According to police officials, the FIR was lodged on Tuesday evening following a complaint by Sub-Inspector Susheel Kumar of the Commissionerate's Media Cell. Investigations revealed that the viral clip, which showed police detaining a man, was actually recorded

on April 11 in the Budhar police station area of Shahdol district in Madhya Pradesh. The footage depicted an inebriated individual creating a public disturbance and had no connection to the labour protests in Noida's Phase-2 or Sector-62 areas. Yet, the RJD leaders allegedly posted it with captions suggesting it was police brutality against protesting workers, thereby spreading misinformation.

The Noida workers' protests, which erupted over demands for wage hikes in factories, have seen sporadic violence, leading to over 350 arrests and seven FIRs so far. Police Commissioner Laxmi Singh has described the unrest as partly fuelled by an 'organised syndicate' using social media to amplify rumours.

Women's reservation bill to significantly strengthen women empowerment: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tirupati/New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday described the Women's Reservation Bill as a landmark and far-reaching initiative that will significantly strengthen women's empowerment in the country. She said the legislation is poised to open new avenues for women and elevate their role in governance in the years ahead.

Speaking during her visit to Tirupati, the Chief Minister said the entire nation is looking at the bill with hope and expectation. "It will ensure meaningful participation of women in the mainstream of decision-making," she said, adding that it represents a decisive step towards inclusive governance.

During the visit, the chief minister offered prayers at the Sri Padmavathi Ammavari Temple, seeking peace, prosperity and good health for citizens. She



described the temple as a timeless centre of faith and devotion, where devotees experience a deep sense of spiritual energy and grace.

She also visited the Integrated Command and Control Centre of the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), praising its use of modern technology and efficient management systems. Gupta noted that the centre plays a crucial role in ensuring the safety of pilgrims and facilitating smooth darshan. "The seamless blend of tradition and technology here is exemplary and can serve as a model for religious institu-

tions across the country," she said. Reflecting on her visit to the Tirupati Balaji shrine, the Chief Minister said she felt a deep sense of spiritual fulfilment. She highlighted that lakhs of devotees from across India and abroad visit the shrine, and commended the administration for maintaining high standards of cleanliness, security and crowd management.

"Managing darshan for 70,000 to one lakh devotees daily without inconvenience is truly commendable," she said, congratulating the TTD team for their efforts.

Over 120 students join Heritage Week at Mehrauli Archaeological Park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 120 students from five schools participated in competitions at Mehrauli Archaeological Park on Wednesday as part of Heritage Week celebrations organised by the Delhi Development Authority.

The event focused on engaging young students with Delhi's cultural and historical legacy through outdoor learning activities. Officials said the initiative aims to move learning beyond classrooms and encourage direct interaction with heritage sites.

Students from both government and private schools took part in large numbers. The activities included dialogue competition, story writing competition, and sketching and drawing competition.

These events gave participants an opportunity to express their understanding of history, culture, and conservation through different forms of creativity.



Officials said the competitions were designed to help students develop a deeper connection with heritage spaces. They added that such initiatives play an important role in building awareness about conservation among young citizens. The same set of activities will continue on April 16 at the park to allow participation from more schools. Authorities expect a larger turnout as the programme expands.

The ongoing Heritage Week celebrations, which began on April 13, will continue until April 18. The week-long programme includes a mix of educational and public engagement activities such as heritage walks, exhibitions, and an online photog-

raphy contest. The photography contest is being organised in collaboration with MyGov and is open to participants from across the country.

A public heritage walk is scheduled for April 17. It will offer visitors a guided experience through the historic landscape of the park. Officials said the walk will help participants understand the architectural and cultural significance of the site.

As part of the celebrations, a photo exhibition is also being held at the Metcalfe House Interpretation Centre from April 14 to April 18. The exhibition showcases conservation and restoration work carried out by the DDA and the Archaeological Survey of India.

The display includes before-and-after images of restored monuments and rare historical photographs. These visuals highlight the transformation of several heritage structures within the park and provide insight into preservation efforts over time.

HC administration directs removal of videos from Kejriwal's hearing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court administration has asked the city police to take steps for removing from social media unauthorised recordings of the court proceedings related to AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal's plea in the liquor policy matter, even as a complaint sought action against the party leaders who shared the clips.

Advocate Vaibhav Singh, while submitting his complaint to the registrar general against Kejriwal and others for unauthorised recording and circulation of the clips, was informed on Wednesday that the high court has already taken note of the videos and directed law enforcement agencies to take steps to take down the content.

Kejriwal had appeared on Monday before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma and submitted his arguments on his plea for her recusal from hearing the CBI appeal against the trial court order discharging him and other accused in the excise policy case.

Besides Kejriwal, Singh also sought action against AAP leaders Manish Sisodia, Saurabh Bhardwaj, Sanjay Singh, Sanjeev Jha, Mukesh



Ahlawat and others, as well as Congress leader Digvijay Singh for sharing the clips of the court proceedings on social media.

Another lawyer also mentioned his petition for an urgent hearing before a bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Anish Dayal regarding the circulation of court videos.

Chief Justice Upadhyaya, however, declined the urgent listing, saying, "You have filed, it will be listed. What is the urgency?"

Vaibhav Singh, in his complaint, said sharing video/audio of judicial proceedings was prohibited under the high court rules and alleged that the politicians' conduct was an act to "create pressure on the judge". The conduct of the political leaders, the complaint alleged, "reflects some conspiracy to mislead the general public of the country and malign the image of the noble institution".

SOUTH EASTERN COALFIELDS LIMITED
"A MINI RATNA COMPANY"
NOTICE
All the tenders issued by SECL for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of SECL <http://www.secl-cil.in>, CIL e-procurement portal <http://coalindiatenders.nic.in> and Central Public Procurement Portal <http://eprocure.gov.in> In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <http://gem.gov.in>. SECL's mining services tenders are also now available on GeM portal <http://gem.gov.in>

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all, JEEWAN LAL PANDEY S/o LATE SH. RAM NARESH PANDEY owner/purchaser of DDA SFS Flat No. 2513 GROUND FLOOR, CAT-III, SECTOR-D, POCKET-2, VASANT KUNJ, NEW DELHI-110070, have applied for certified copies in DDA. The original documents i.e. ALLOCATION LETTER, POSSESSION LETTER, NOC FOR WATER AND ELECTRICITY CONNECTION, SITE POSSESSION SUP & OTHER RELEVANT DOCUMENTS of the above said flat have been lost. An LR No. 2351/95/2026 dated 15/04/2026 to this effect has been lodged in P.S. Crime Branch, Delhi. Any person claiming any right, interest, having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may write/contact with above named person at above Address/Phone No. 8010699900 within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objection with respect to this property, can personally inform or write to Deputy Director (Housing) or Director (Housing), Delhi Development Authority, Vikas Sadan, New Delhi-110023.

FORM INC-26
(Pursuant to Rule 4 of the Companies (Authorized to Register) Rules, 2014)
NOTICE is hereby given that pursuant to sub-section (1) of Section 13 and Section 12 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 4 of the Companies (Authorized to Register) Rules, 2014, INSIGHT SOLUTIONS PRIVATE LIMITED, having CIN U72900DL2014PTC273493 and having its registered Office at Flat No. 310, Ground Floor, Type-A, Pocket-7, DDA, Sector-A-6, Narela, Landmark: Near Harish Chandra Hospital, New Delhi-110040, has resolved to shift its Registered Office from the State of Delhi to the State of Haryana and to alter Clause-II of the Memorandum of Association of the Company accordingly. Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed alteration of the Memorandum of Association may intimate his/her objections, if any, to the Regional Director (Northern Region), Ministry of Corporate Affairs, within 21 days from the date of publication of this notice, in writing. Dated this 16th day of April 2026. For and on the behalf of Board of Directors In Insight Solutions Private Limited (Dinesh Rana) Director DIN=0986541 Dated: 16/04/2026 Place: Delhi

CHANGE OF NAME
I, Neeti D/o Sh. Reshampal Koli, R/o H. No. EK-37, Sector-9, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201012, hereby declare that my name is recorded as "Neeti Koli" in some records, whereas in my Aadhaar Card No. 9555 4713 6347 and PAN No. ARBPN2217L, my name is "Neeti". Both names "Neeti Koli" and "Neeti" refer to one and the same person. Henceforth, I shall be known as "Neeti" for all purposes.

CHANGE OF NAME
I, Markandan T Father of No. 14892409W Sep/MT Ajith M, R/o- Vill- Mattapparai, PO- Kalladipatti, Taluk- Nilakottai Dist- Dindigul, Tamilnadu - 624201, have changed my name from Markandan T to Markandan Thavasidevar, vide affidavit dated 15/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Indoor Medical Records of the patients admitted during financial year 2022-2023 (from 01.04.2022 to 31.03.2023) are scheduled to be disposed off as per hospital policy. Any patient requiring his/her Medical Records may approach the undersigned within 30 days failing which the records will be disposed off without further notice. Medical Superintendent Kailash Hospital & Neuro Institute NH-1, Sector 71 Noida

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Asha Devi had acquired Plot measuring 200 sq. yds., Out of Khata no. 106, at village Ithabans, Pargana and Tehsil Dadri, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar U.P. vide Sale Deed dated 27.03.2015. Original Sale deed dt.1.08.2004 executed in favour of Mr. Nanak Chand Sharma, do. no. 4264, w.r.t above said property is Lost. Now Mrs. Asha Devi is the undisputed owner of above said properties and is willing to Mortgage the above said property with
OR Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby requested to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, no claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.
Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H.No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lalpat Nagar 4, New Delhi 110024

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, KRISHAN MOHAN SINGH S/o Ambika Prasad Singh R/o F-8/8, Poorvi Marg, Vasant Vihar, South West Delhi, Delhi-110057 have changed my name from KRISHAN MOHAN SINGH to KISHAN MOHAN SINGH. Henceforth I would be known by the name of KISHAN MOHAN SINGH for all future purposes. PD(874)C I, KRISHAN MOHAN SINGH S/o Ambika Prasad Singh R/o F-8/8, Poorvi Marg, Vasant Vihar, South West Delhi, Delhi-110057 have changed my name from KRISHAN MOHAN SINGH to KISHAN MOHAN SINGH. Henceforth I would be known by the name of KISHAN MOHAN SINGH for all future purposes. PD(875)C I, Saroj W/o Ram Ladaite R/o I-1603-I, Block, Jahangirpuri, Delhi-110033, have changed my name to Saroj Devi (Saroj and Saroj Devi is Same Person PD(876)C I, No. 15450356K Hav Tantarapale Shubham Dadarao, Serving at- Army Hospital R&R, Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my mother's name in my service record from Rekha to Rekha Dadarao Tantarapale, vide affidavit dated 15/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(877)C

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Prem Nath Singh is the owner of A Residential House No. 48/11, Shri Ram Chandra Saini, Meru Scheme No. 7, Sector-4, Shastri Nagar, Pargana, Tehsil & District Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, Same is Owned by Sale Deed Dated 26.03.2004 Document No.1614 that Chain Document Sale Deed Dated 08.10.2003 Document No.18392 executed by Mr. Raees Ahmed So. Late Mr. Abdul Hameed in favour of Mrs. Anwari Begum W/o. Late Mr. Abdul Hameed that this Sale Deed has been lost that Mr. Prem Nath Singh informed to U.P Police on dated 14.04.2026 vide LAR No. 2026000043354, That Husain Mehdi & Mrs. Shamnoon Sharma are Mortgaging this property with Grisham Housing Finance Ltd. All Persons are hereby informed that if anybody has found these documents or Any Person, Corporation, company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest title in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 14 days of the present. Rohit Kumar Advocate (Mechanical Engineering) 26/04/1979 which was executed by Kela Devi and same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucien Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41607327

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ESAF SMALL FINANCE BANK
GOLD AUCTION NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the public that gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd. against various loan accounts and remaining overdue/unredeemed despite repeated notices will be auctioned for recovery of the Bank's dues, in accordance with applicable banking regulations and policies.
DETAILS OF AUCTION
Mode of Auction: Off-line (Physical Auction through Branches)
Date of Auction: 20-05-2026 Time: 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM
Auction Venues: The auction will be conducted at the following ESAF Small Finance Bank branches in Haryana
Interested bidders are requested to visit the respective branches for participation. For detailed branch addresses and contact numbers, please visit the Bank's official website
BRANCH NAME - LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBER
Faridabad: 75250003281479.
Important Instructions: Borrowers may redeem their pledged gold ornaments by clearing the total dues along with applicable charges at least two days prior to the auction date. Interested bidders must carry valid KYC documents. GST Registration Number is mandatory for firms/companies, wherever applicable. Bidders are required to deposit an Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of Rs.2,500 before participating in the auction. The auction will be conducted on an "as is where is" and "as is what is" basis. The Bank reserves the right to cancel/postpone the auction or reject any bid without assigning any reason. Participation in the auction shall be deemed acceptance of all terms and conditions of the Bank. The Minimum Reserve Price will be fixed by bank on the basis of IBJA Rate as applicable on the basis of purity of Gold.
Place: Thrissur Date: 16 April 2026 (Sd/-) Authorized Signatory ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Mr. Rishabh Bhardwaj has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Ghaziabad, U.P. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of HIG Flat No. 19, Young Executive GGHS Ltd., Shobhagya Apartments, Plot No. 19/1, Sector-9, Rohini, Delhi from Mrs. Charu Kad & Mr. Laksh Kad, who have represented that they are the absolute owners of the said property, having inherited the same from Mr. Brij Mohan Kapur through his Will dated 26.02.2014 (Doc. No. 617), who was the owner of the said property by virtue of Conveyance Deed dated 05.05.2017 (Doc. No. 5378). If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.
Amit Kumar, Advocate GNA & Associates D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110014

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that Mr. Amit Katariya is the Owner of the Plot no. 194, area measuring 63 sq. yards, out of Khata no. 15999/2915 situated at village Hal Abadi Lakshman Vihar, Gurugram, Residential colony known as "Laxman Vihar" Tehsil & Distt. Gurugram through Transfer Deed dated 31.05.2024 doc. no. 2515 executed by Mrs. Meenu Badwar through GPA Mrs. Sarita Katariya in favour of Mr. Amit Katariya in respect of Land area measuring 63 sq. yards, out of Khata no. 15999/2915 of above said property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Maharindev Nolkal & Himani. Subsequently, Mr. Maharindev Nolkal & Himani are in the process of mortgaging the said property with Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within 15 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 07-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 15-days period by contacting Law Veritas North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +9102-0499731, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, JC-573336L Nb/Sub Dheeraj, R/o- Vill- Kwili, PO- Kurhan, Dist- Rudraprayag, Uttarakhand- 246495, have changed my Son's name from Gaurav Chander to Gaurav Chandra, vide affidavit dated 15/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(880)C I, JC-573336L Nb/Sub Dheeraj, R/o- Vill- Kwili, PO- Kurhan, Dist- Rudraprayag, Uttarakhand- 246495, have changed my Son's name from Abhay Chander to Abhay Chandra, vide affidavit dated 15/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(881)C I, JC-573336L Nb/Sub Dheeraj, R/o- Vill- Kwili, PO- Kurhan, Dist- Rudraprayag, Uttarakhand- 246495, have changed my Son's name from Abhay Chander to Abhay Chandra, vide affidavit dated 15/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(882)C

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Prem Nath Singh is the owner of A Residential House No. 48/11, Shri Ram Chandra Saini, Meru Scheme No. 7, Sector-4, Shastri Nagar, Pargana, Tehsil & District Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, Same is Owned by Sale Deed Dated 26.03.2004 Document No.1614 that Chain Document Sale Deed Dated 08.10.2003 Document No.18392 executed by Mr. Raees Ahmed So. Late Mr. Abdul Hameed in favour of Mrs. Anwari Begum W/o. Late Mr. Abdul Hameed that this Sale Deed has been lost that Mr. Prem Nath Singh informed to U.P Police on dated 14.04.2026 vide LAR No. 2026000043354, That Husain Mehdi & Mrs. Shamnoon Sharma are Mortgaging this property with Grisham Housing Finance Ltd. All Persons are hereby informed that if anybody has found these documents or Any Person, Corporation, company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest title in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 14 days of the present. Rohit Kumar Advocate (Mechanical Engineering) 26/04/1979 which was executed by Kela Devi and same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucien Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41607327

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Open E-Tender Notice
For and on behalf of President of India: Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer (Fr.), Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites open e-tender on 'SINGLE PACKET SYSTEM' for following work from experienced and capable tenders.
1 Name of Work : PU Painting of steam locomotives, Road Rollers, Steam Crane, heritage coach and lounge car at Steam locomotive Shed Rewari as per Scope of Work
2 Work Place : Rewari, Haryana
3 Period of Work : Six (06) Months
4 Advertised Value : Rs. 31,52,212.15/- (including provision of GST)
5 Earnest Money to be deposited : Rs. 63100.00/-, through net banking or gateway only
6 Tender Document Cost : Nil
7 Date and Time availability of E-Tender Document: From 13.04.2026 at 15:04 hrs
8 Date and time of E-Tender Closing : 05/05/2026 at 12:00 hrs
9 Date and time of E-Tender opening: On 05.05.2026 after 12:00 hrs, if the date of opening happens to be holiday then E-Tender shall be opened on the next working day
10 Place for opening E-Tender: Mechanical Department, Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi-55
Note: The complete particulars of the tender may be found in website www.reps.gov.in. No: NRDLIOMCNW402025RT Date: 15/04/2026 1251/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Galileo spyware, ISI claims: Conspiracy in Assembly bomb threats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A fresh threat email sent to Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on April 14 claimed that five RDX bombs would be detonated inside the Delhi Assembly within two hours and alleged that Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI had tested bomb detection systems (BDDS) at the premises the previous day. The email, sent from the address sourav_biswasi@outlook.com in the name of Sourav Biswas Khan, warned: "Ignore at your own risk."

The email, written in Hindi and addressed personally to the Speaker, went beyond a simple bomb threat. It

alleged a conspiracy involving Pakistan's ISI and a political party, claimed the sender had access to confidential police intelligence reports, and named specific individuals, including a retired IPS officer from Tamil Nadu.

The email claimed that spyware called "Remote Control Systems (RCS) Galileo," purchased from an Italian company called "Hacking Team," was being used by Pakistan's representatives in Coimbatore to obtain confidential daily situation reports issued by police. It alleged that the software was being used for blackmail. The email concluded with a direct message to the Speaker: "Do not think that you can ever catch us.

Now you only have one thing to do. Run."

This is the sixth bomb threat email received by the Delhi Assembly since the Budget Session last month. On Monday, April 13, a separate threat email claimed that 15 RDX bombs laced with cyanide gas would be detonated within three hours and demanded the evacuation of Muslim employees from the premises.

Another email on the same day claimed 16 RDX-laden improvised explosive devices had been planted inside the Assembly, with a warning of detonation at 1:40 PM. Security agencies evacuated the building and conducted thorough checks. Nothing suspicious was found.



Three threat emails were received during the Budget Session itself, on March 23, 24, and 25. All were found to be hoaxes after thorough police checks. Officials said the sender of earlier emails was allegedly traced to Coimbatore and had cited

political grievances, and efforts to verify the authenticity of all threats are ongoing.

The wave of threats has spread beyond the Assembly. On Wednesday, Lok Nayak Bhavan near Khan Market also received a bomb threat email, following which the building was evacuated, and teams, including dog squads, bomb disposal units, and fire services, were deployed. Police said nothing suspicious was found, and searches continued.

Speaker Gupta has written to Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golcha seeking urgent action. In a letter dated April 15 to Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golcha, the Speaker described the threat as a matter of grave concern, noting that it was the first time such an email had directly addressed him by name. He said the message originated from the email address sourav.biswasi@outlook.com and contained references to alleged links involving Pakistan's ISI.

Gupta pointed out that the email was received while the Assembly premises were hosting celebrations for the birth anniversary of Dr BR Ambedkar. He said the timing of such threats aimed at disrupting key proceedings and official events of the Assembly.

He also noted that earlier emails were received during the Budget Session, suggesting a pattern intended to interfere with legislative functioning. The Speaker wrote this letter to the Delhi Police Commissioner in continuation of his earlier communication dated 13th April 2026, following the receipt of the bomb threat mail on Monday.

The repeated threats come in the backdrop of a serious

security breach at the Assembly on April 6, when a car with a Uttar Pradesh registration rammed through Gate No. 2, drove to the Speaker's porch, and left a bouquet and garland before fleeing. Three suspects were subsequently detained.

"The repeatedly received threat emails not only hamper the smooth functioning of the Assembly but also instil a sense of fear among the staff working there," the Speaker said.

"The Delhi Legislative Assembly is a very important democratic institution, and any threat to it is a threat to the democratic system itself." Investigation into the source of all threat emails is underway.

Couple, toddler charred to death in fire near Budh Vihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



A massive fire broke out in a cluster of shanties in the Budh Vihar area in New Delhi

ered three charred bodies from the debris. The deceased were identified as Mosibur Dastagir (23), his wife Monara Sekh (19), and their two-year-old daughter.

Officials said the fire spread quickly due to the highly combustible nature of the materials used in the shanties, including tarpaulin sheets, scrap items and other flammable waste stored in and around the huts. Eyewitnesses said that the

fire spread within minutes, leaving little time for residents to react. However, four other occupants of the cluster managed to escape.

"The toddler could have been saved, but the flames spread so fast that everything was engulfed in no time," a neighbour said.

He added that the couple tried to push the child out, but just then, the tin roof, along with the tarpaulin, collapsed.

"Mosibur had locked the door at night because thefts are common here. When the fire broke out, he could not find the key. He even tried to break the lock with a knife, but before the family could get out, the burning roof came crashing down," he said. Visuals from the scene showed the entire plot reduced to ashes, with charred remains, including what seemed to be bones, scattered across the site.

Burnt household items — a refrigerator frame, coolers, utensils, gas cylinders and plastic containers — lied amid debris.

Nearby buildings were not spared either. Residents said water tanks installed on adjacent rooftops were damaged due to the intense heat, while electrical wires in the narrow lanes melted. Many in the neighbourhood initially mistook the sound of explosions for something else.

"We heard a series of loud bangs during the night,"

another neighbour said.

"At first, we thought it was a wedding procession because there are banquet halls nearby. But when the sounds continued and we checked the time, we stepped out and saw huge flames rising from the shanties," he added.

The inconsolable family members of the victims said several locals are natives of West Bengal and were soon going to leave for their hometowns ahead of the assembly elections.

"We were planning to return to our hometown in a few days for the elections," Monara's mother, a native of the South 24 Parganas district of West Bengal, said.

She added that the family had been living in Delhi for nearly four years but had moved to the Budh Vihar locality only two months ago because there was a severe electricity and water shortage where they used to live earlier.

Mukarba Chowk underpass nears completion, set to open soon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The long-awaited Mukarba Chowk underpass in North Delhi is nearly complete and is expected to be opened to the public within the next few days, offering major relief to commuters facing chronic traffic congestion at one of the city's busiest intersections.

Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh conducted an on-site inspection of the project on Wednesday and reviewed the final stages of construction. Officials informed him that around 98 per cent of the work has been completed, with finishing touches currently underway.

The underpass has been built at Mukarba Chowk on Outer Ring Road using advanced jack pushing technology with pre-cast reinforced concrete box struc-



tures. The project aims to ease congestion at the busy junction, which often witnesses long traffic jams during peak hours.

Speaking during the inspection, the minister said the area has been a major bottleneck for years. He noted that the new infrastructure is designed to address this problem and improve traffic flow significantly. He added that the project will be inaugurated soon under the leadership of the Chief Minister.

The underpass will provide seamless connectivity

between Badli and Rohini on one side and Azadpur and Jahangirpuri on the other. This will allow vehicles to bypass the congested intersection, reducing delays and improving travel efficiency.

According to officials, nearly 15,800 vehicles are expected to use the underpass daily. The project is likely to reduce travel time by up to 10 minutes per vehicle and shorten the travel distance by around one kilometre. This is expected to translate into significant fuel savings for commuters.

Fuel, LPG supplies normal in Delhi: CM



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday reiterated that there is no need for residents to panic as fuel and LPG supplies remain normal and adequate in the national Capital, with around 1.25 lakh LPG cylinders delivered daily in line with regular demand.

According to an official statement, Gupta said the average delivery time for LPG cylinders continues to be maintained at four to five days. Claiming that there is no shortage of LPG, petrol or diesel in Delhi or across the country amid the conflict in West Asia, the chief minister appealed to people to ignore rumours and avoid panic buying.

"All gas agencies and bottling plants have sufficient stocks, and uninterrupted distribution is being ensured through multiple

supply channels. The government is closely monitoring the system to prevent any inconvenience to consumers," the statement quoted Gupta as saying.

To streamline services, consumers are being encouraged to book LPG refills through SMS, interactive voice response systems (IVRS), social media and online portals, she said.

An OTP-based delivery authentication system has also been implemented, with over 90 per cent of daily deliveries now being verified, the chief minister said. Under the Free Trade LPG (FTL) scheme, 5-kg cylinders are being provided to migrant workers at gas agencies against a valid identity proof.

Special camps and outreach drives are also being organised across districts in coordination with local authorities to improve access to these services, Gupta said.

Priority must be given to issues flagged by citizens: LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday emphasised that sustained priority must be given to effective garbage management, timely road repairs, dust mitigation, and swift resolution of issues flagged by citizens and the media.

Giving this direction while reviewing the status and progress of key initiatives and ongoing works undertaken by the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), he also advised the civic body NDMC to remain open and responsive to feedback in a constructive manner.



Sandhu also urged it to bridge the gap between on-ground realities and service delivery expectations—an essential prerequisite for achieving citizen-centric governance.

The Lt Governor's meeting with the NDMC chairman

focused on addressing operational challenges, augmenting infrastructure, and ensuring the effective delivery of essential civic services across the New Delhi area.

As the urban local body entrusted with managing the core of the National

Capital, the NDMC carries the responsibility of delivering services that are not only efficient and citizen-centric but also replicable as models of global standards and best practices.

In this context, the following key areas were highlighted for focused action:

Exploring the adoption of advanced technologies and global best practices for efficient waste management.

Developing pedestrian-friendly solutions in high-footfall areas such as Khan Market and Connaught Place.

Examining measures to rationalise power tariffs for NDMC residents to reduce their financial burden.

Govt to roll out 150 electric buses on April 17

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning to roll out 150 additional electric buses on April 17, its third such launch this year, officials said.

In a push for green mobility in the Capital, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) has launched around 800 electric buses this year alone, taking the total number of city buses close to 6,500.

In February, marking the BJP government's one year in power, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched 500 buses from Ramliha Maidan.

Subsequently, in March, 300 more electric buses were



launched by the government.

"The Government is continuously increasing its bus fleet and delivering on its commitments. These new electric buses would not only improve connectivity but also cut down air pollu-

tion. The buses are fully equipped with CCTV cameras, panic buttons, real-time tracking, and other facilities," Delhi Transport Minister Pankaj Singh said.

According to officials, the 150 new buses will be

flagged off from the East Vinod Nagar depot, along with the inauguration of a new office building.

In this year's budget envisaging an "emission-free" Delhi, Gupta announced that the Government plans to have 7,500 buses by March next year, with 5,800 electric buses among them.

The Delhi Government has allocated ₹8,374 crore for the transport department in financial year 2026-27.

Last week, the Delhi government also launched its draft EV Policy 2.0 which aims to promote adoption of clean mobility through various incentives and regulatory measures.

97.38% pass CBSE Class 10 exams in Delhi



Students celebrating after the Class 10 Board examination results in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded a strong overall pass percentage of 97.38 per cent in the Class 10 board examinations declared by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Wednesday, reflecting stable academic performance across the capital.

Among the two administrative zones, Delhi West performed slightly better with a pass percentage of 97.45 per cent, while Delhi East recorded 97.33 per cent. A total of 3,45,227 students from Delhi appeared in the examination, out of which 3,36,176 successfully cleared it.

At the national level, CBSE reported an overall pass percentage of 93.7 per cent. More than 55,000 students across the country scored above 95 per cent marks, while over 2.21 lakh students secured more than 90 per cent.

Girls continued to outperform boys in the results. The

pass percentage among girls stood at 94.99 per cent, compared to 92.69 per cent for boys. Transgender candidates recorded a pass percentage of 87.50 per cent.

CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj said the results were announced earlier than usual due to faster evaluation. He said nearly 1.6 crore answer sheets were evaluated in record time, enabling the board to declare results almost a month ahead of schedule.

This year, more than 24.71 lakh students appeared for the examinations conducted at 8,074 centres. On February 21 alone, around 24.95 lakh students took exams, making it one of the largest single-day examination exercises. The process involved more than 10 lakh rooms and about 20 lakh invigilators.

In line with the National Education Policy, CBSE introduced a two-phase examination system for Class 10 students this year.

From Ghalib's school to Old Delhi junction: Civic body to create database of heritage landmarks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Anglo Arabic School had invited the legendary poet Mirza Ghalib in 1840 to teach Persian there. The school located at Ajmeri Gate is still operational. For that matter, the legacy of iconic institutions or buildings like the Old Delhi railway station and Tibbia College evokes interest amongst the aficionados of history and heritage.

These passionate lovers of the rich past of the national Capital are in for a pleasant experience, as they can now scan through the updated

official records of centuries-old institutions of the national Capital, courtesy the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD). The civic body will soon undertake a project to identify and document railway stations, schools and colleges in the city that are over 100 years old or more for record-keeping purposes, officials said.

Deputy Commissioners across all 12 zones of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will be tasked with compiling details of such institutions as part of the initiative to create a record of long-standing public build-

ings still in use, officials added.

Among the sites likely to be covered are the 1903 Old Delhi Railway Station, the Anglo-Arabic Senior Secondary School complex at Ajmeri Gate, and the 1916 Tibbia College in Karol Bagh, all of which are still operating. Several schools and colleges in Delhi are over 100 years old, with many featuring historic, heritage-listed, or locally recognised buildings.

Key examples include Zakir Hussain College (dating back to 1792), St Stephen's College (original campus from 1881), and the 125-year-



old Hindu College building at Kashmere Gate. Others founded in the early 20th century include Modern School on Barakhamba Road (1920), Ramjas College (1917), Sri Ram College of Commerce (1926, starting from a bungalow in Daryaganj), and Delhi College of Engineering—now Delhi Technological University—established in 1941 at Kashmere Gate. (Note: Rajputana Rifles Heroes Memorial Senior Secondary School in Delhi Cantonment, at 99 years old.)

"Delhi has a vast number of railway stations and educational institutions which

have served the city for over a century. This exercise will help us to identify these places and maintain an updated record," an official said.

Similarly, the oldest railway station in Delhi is none other than Old Delhi Railway Station, popularly known as Delhi Junction, which is 162 years. Established in April 1864, this railway station was originally designed to handle just 100 passengers a day. Today, however, it caters to over one lakh passengers daily.

The civic body aims to maintain a consolidated

database of such institutions, many of which have continued to serve residents for decades despite rapid urban expansion, officials said, adding that details such as the name of the building, its age, ownership status and current condition will be documented during the process.

The exercise follows an order issued in February. Additionally, assistance will also be sought from the Archaeological Survey of India. Further details on the timeline and scope of the project are awaited, they added.

IN FOCUS



A woman prepares cow dung cakes to sell amid the LPG supply crisis, in Prayagraj

PTI

ED attaches assets worth ₹159 crore in West Bengal coal case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday said it has attached fresh assets worth ₹159 crore in a money laundering investigation linked to alleged illegal coal mining and pilferage in poll-bound West Bengal, a case in which it also raided the political consultancy firm I-PAC.

The attached assets include investments in movable financial instruments such as corporate bonds and alternative investment funds held in the names of entities like Shyam Sel and Power Ltd and Shyam Ferro Alloys Ltd, part of the Shyam Group, managed and controlled by Sanjay Agarwal and Brij



Bhushan Agarwal, the agency said in a statement.

The ED case stems from a November 2020 FIR filed by the CBI, which alleged a multi-crore rupee coal pilferage scam related to Eastern Coalfields Limited mines in West Bengal's Kunustoria and Kajora areas, in and around Asansol. Anup Majee alias

Lala, arrested by the agency a few years ago, has been stated by the ED as the leader of this syndicate.

The agency claimed certain companies in the state "knowingly" purchased illegally excavated coal with cash. It earlier attached assets worth ₹ 322 crore and pegged the estimate of proceeds of crime at ₹2,742 crore. The federal probe agency last conducted searches in this case on January 8. Kolkata premises of the political consultancy firm I-PAC and one of its directors Pratik Jain were among the targets of those raids.

The action led to much controversy and the ED alleged in a press statement that West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee

entered Jain's residence during the raids, "took away key evidence," and followed the same action at the I-PAC office. Banerjee and her party, Trinamool Congress, alleged that the ED, in the garb of searches, tried to take away its election-strategy related documents from I-PAC premises just before the upcoming assembly polls in the State. The ED approached the Calcutta High Court and the Supreme Court seeking a CBI probe into the incident.

The ED claims that the coal syndicate engaged in "illegal" excavation and "widespread" coal pilferage, distributing coal to multiple factories in West Bengal with the "active facilitation" of local administrative elements.

RS Chairman reconstitutes panel of vice-chairpersons

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Wednesday reconstituted the panel of vice-chairpersons, including Dinesh Sharma, Phangnon Konyak and M Thambi Durai in the committee.

Others part of the panel as vice-chairpersons include Sasmit Patra, Phulo Devi Netam and Ghanshyam Tewari. "The (Rajya Sabha) chairman has re-constituted the panel of vice-chairpersons, April 15, 2026, with the following members - Dinesh Sharma, S Phangnon Konyak, M Thambi Durai, Sasmit Patra, Phulo Devi Netam and Ghanshyam Tiwari," an official notification said.

The election to fill the vacant deputy chairman's post will be held at 11 am on April 17, with Harivansh



Narayan Singh likely to be renominated to the position.

Harivansh had been the Rajya Sabha deputy chairman for two consecutive terms till his retirement on April 9.

He has since been nominated to the Rajya Sabha by President Droupadi Murmu and has already taken the oath.

Global growth needs unconstricted energy markets: Jaishankar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Against the backdrop of closure of the Strait of Hormuz, India on Wednesday made a strong pitch for unimpeded transit of merchant vessels, with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar asserting that attacks on shipping are "completely unacceptable."

In his remarks at a Japan-hosted meeting that focused on disruptions in energy supplies in the wake of the West Asia crisis, Jaishankar said global growth demands that energy markets are "not constricted". The external affairs minister represented India at the "Asia Zero-Emission Community (AZEC) plus" meeting while joining it through virtual mode. The meeting was chaired by Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi.

"Underlined India's strong commitment to safe and unimpeded transit passage of maritime shipping. Attacks on merchant shipping are completely unacceptable. Global growth demands that energy markets are not constricted," Jaishankar said on social media. "As a major energy consumer, India will work



with like-minded partners to develop supply chain resilience," he said.

The meeting was joined by 11 members of AZEC such as Australia and Singapore and the grouping's partner nations India, Bangladesh and South Korea.

At the meeting, Japan released a new initiative called Partnership On Wide Energy and Resources Resilience (POWER) Asia to provide financial cooperation to Asian countries impacted by fuel supply shortages and supply chain disruptions. The financial support totalling about USD 10 billion will be used to provide fiscal support to Asian governments, strengthening energy supply systems and diversifying energy sources, the Japanese foreign ministry said.

Central agencies probes PFI links in TCS Nashik religious coercion

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

Central agencies involved in the probe have found footprints of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI) in the Nashik TCS case. PFI has been accused by agencies like NIA of promoting radicalisation through 'love jihad'.

The alleged pattern, as per the PFI's vision document 2047, coaxes Muslim employees in supervisory roles, systematically targeting young Hindu women with a mix of sexual pressure, emotional manipulation and Dawah-style religious persuasion.

In the TCS Nashik scandal, the same pattern has tell-tale signs of grooming of Hindu women. WhatsApp groups and coordinated behaviour inside the office suggest deep planning, not isolated



misconduct. PFI is a banned Islamist organisation (proscribed in 2022) accused by agencies like NIA of promoting radicalisation, 'Love Jihad' (targeted interfaith relationships for conversion), grooming and using influential positions or networks for religious conversion and extremism.

Investigators found references to a Malaysia-linked preacher named Imran, aka Irman, in reports, who was allegedly introduced to victims

and employees via video calls for religious talks. Malaysia has been cited in some radicalisation probes before, and this has widened the case into possible international/networked activity.

Nashik Police have shared the SIT report with central agencies NIA, Maharashtra ATS and IB to check for a larger pan-India or networked conspiracy. Some reports say the NIA may probe it, or it has become part of the investigation.

Meanwhile, the Special Investigation Team (SIT), led by ACP (Crime) Sandeep Mitke under the direct supervision of Nashik Police Commissioner Sandeep Karnik, has consolidated its probe into nine FIRs registered between March 26 and April 3, 2026, at Deolali Camp and other stations.

The investigation covers alleged sexual exploitation, workplace

harassment, and religious coercion at the TCS BPO unit in Satpur MIDC, spanning a chilling four-year pattern from July 2022 to early 2026.

SIT has mapped a systematic pattern rather than isolated incidents. Victims are primarily Hindu women (aged 18-25); sexual harassment, inappropriate touching, staring at chests, obscene remarks on bodies and personal lives, persistent advances, double-meaning comments, gestures toward private parts, increased workload for non-compliance, and molestation.

One serious case involves Tausif Attar allegedly establishing physical relations with a complainant under the false pretext of marriage. Mocking Hindu deities and beliefs, abusive language targeting religion, pressure to consume non-vegetarian food, offering Namaz, changing dressing style and attempts at reli-

gious conversion. One victim was reportedly influenced to observe Ramzan fasts and adopt Islamic practices.

The SIT has recovered 78 emails and chats from the arrested HR AGM's devices, which are under active scrutiny in her presence. These include senior managers escalating complaints against two accused employees for sexual harassment, which allegedly received no response.

SIT is also examining call records, CCTV footage, WhatsApp groups, and bank statements to determine if internal grievances were deliberately ignored or suppressed, sources said.

Nida Khan, the AGM (HR), is under the scanner for allegedly acting as a facilitator and introducing victims to the accused team leaders and enabling befriendings.

Himanta calls Rahul crazy over corruption charges

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma threw a "crazy person" barb at Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday after the Congress leader accused him of "abusing State power to harass his political opponents and critics".

Sarma, who arrived at the airport here before proceeding to Puri to pray at the Jagannath Temple, challenged Gandhi to make his passport details public and reveal which countries the leader of the opposi-



tion in the Lok Sabha had visited.

His scathing remarks came after Gandhi termed Sarma "most corrupt

in the country" and said the Congress stood with Pawan Khera, who has alleged that the Assam CM's wife has multiple passports and offshore properties, which were not declared in the chief minister's election affidavit.

The Sarmas have rejected the allegations as false.

In a post on X, Gandhi alleged, "The present CM of Assam is the most corrupt in the country. He will not escape the law. His abuse of State power to harass his political opponents and critics is against the Constitution."

Govt allays doubts on women's bill

According to the draft Constitution amendment bill, which will be introduced and is expected to be passed in the upcoming special sitting of Parliament, seats would also be increased in State and Union territory assemblies to accommodate 33 per cent reservation for women.

Amending the Constitution requires a special majority in both Houses of Parliament: a majority of the total membership (more than 50 per cent) and a two-thirds majority of members present and voting. So if all 540 members, who are in the House currently, are present and voting, the two-thirds majority mark would be 360. The total strength of the NDA in the Lok Sabha stands at 292, while the major Opposition parties have 233 MPs.

The ruling NDA is pitching the move for early implementation of the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam' as a "historic step". In a letter to the Parliamentarians as well as women of the country, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has asserted that Indian democracy will become stronger and more vibrant if elections to the Lok Sabha and the various assemblies in 2029 are held with the women's quota fully in place.

BJP's first CM in Bihar sworn in

Also present at the oath taking were Union minister and former BJP president JP Nadda and Chirag Paswan, who heads the LJP (RV), the third-largest constituent of the ruling NDA in Bihar.

Bijendra Prasad Yadav and Vijay Kumar Chaudhary, both from the JD(U), also took oath on the occasion as deputy chief ministers. NDA sources said they were expecting a cabinet expansion at the earliest, since the current arrangement left no scope to ensure that different caste groups were represented.

Chaudhary is a Koeri, a powerful OBC group, while Vijay Kumar Chaudhary is a Bhumihar, an upper caste group that is known to be inclined more towards the BJP than his own JD (U). Bijendra Prasad Yadav belongs to the state's most populous OBC group which has been aligned with the RJD, the main Opposition party in the State. Until the allocation of cabinet berths, the new CM has kept with himself close to 29 portfolios, including crucial ones like home, vigilance, revenue and land reforms and health. The other departments that remain with the CM include agriculture, labour resources and migrant

workers welfare, disaster management, panchayat raj and industries.

Vijay Kumar Chaudhary has been allocated 10 departments, including water resources, parliamentary affairs and information and public relations, portfolios that he held in the previous Nitish Kumar Government.

Yadav will hold eight departments, including energy, finance and planning and development, which he had been entrusted with in the previous Government. He has also been allocated the prohibition, excise and registration department. The JD(U) is expecting that the cabinet includes a Kumi, the OBC group to which Nitish Kumar belongs, and a Muslim, in line with the party's strategy of projecting a secular image. At present, the cabinet has no Dalit and no woman. Representation of both is a must in the current political climate.

PM Modi congratulated Choudhary and said his energy, dedication to public service and grassroots experience will prove extremely beneficial for the State. "Heartiest congratulations and best wishes to Samrat Choudhary on taking oath as the Chief Minister of Bihar! His energy, dedication to public service, and grassroots experience will prove extremely beneficial for the state. I am fully confident that under his capable leadership, while fulfilling the aspirations of the people, Bihar will touch new heights of all-round development," the PM Modi posted on social media.

Choudhary has been in politics for nearly three decades though the 57-year-old leader joined the BJP only nine years ago. "I will get down to work from today itself. Rest assured that the model of governance developed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and ex-CM Nitish Kumar will be followed in Bihar," Choudhary said after the swearing in ceremony.

After the oath-taking ceremony, the chief minister went to the secretariat where he held a meeting with Government officials, whom he briefed about priorities of his administration. Later, Choudhary also visited the BJP office where he was felicitated by party workers.

Mediators race to extend US-Iran truce

The commander of Iran's joint military command warned Wednesday that Iran would completely block exports and imports across the Persian Gulf region, the Sea of Oman, and the Red Sea if the US military does not lift its blockade on Iranian ports.

"Iran will act with strength to defend its national sovereignty and its interests," said Ali

Abdollahi, calling the blockade "a prelude to violating the ceasefire." His comments were reported by Iranian state media.

Before the two-week ceasefire expires on April 22, mediators are pushing for a compromise on three main sticking points that derailed direct talks last weekend — Iran's nuclear program, the Strait of Hormuz and compensation for wartime damages — according to one of the regional officials who is involved in mediation efforts.

Both officials spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the matter.

World leaders including US President Donald Trump and UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres said on Tuesday that revived talks in the upcoming days were likely.

The fighting has killed at least 3,000 people in Iran, more than 2,100 in Lebanon, 23 in Israel and more than a dozen in Gulf Arab states. Thirteen US service members have also been killed. The war, now in its seventh week, has jolted markets and rattled the global economy as shipping has been cut off and airstrikes have torn through military and civilian infrastructure across the region. Oil prices fell on hopes for an end to fighting on Wednesday, and US stocks surged close to records set in January.

Yet whether the fragile ceasefire would hold appeared increasingly uncertain as the US pressed ahead with its blockade, which threatens to sever Iran from economic lifelines it has relied on since the war began nearly seven weeks ago. "I think they want to make a deal very badly," Trump said in an excerpt from an interview with Fox Business Network's "Mornings with Maria" scheduled to air Wednesday morning. He added: "I view it as very close to over."

A US official said Tuesday that fresh talks with Iran were still under discussion and that nothing has been scheduled. The official spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss sensitive negotiations.

Muhammad Aurangzeb, Pakistan's finance minister, told The Associated Press that "our leadership is not giving up" on efforts to help the U.S. and Iran end the conflict.

Trump on Wednesday claimed that China has agreed not to provide weapons to Iran as reports circulate that Beijing has considered transferring arms. Trump wrote in a social media post that China is "very happy that I am permanently opening the Strait of Hormuz." He added: "They have agreed not to send weapons to Iran." He seemed to suggest the two are linked.

China has long supported Iran's ballistic missile program and backed it with dual-use industrial components that can be used for

missile production, according to the US Government.

Opposition unites against delimitation

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge echoed the strategy of the Opposition parties and said they have decided to unitedly vote against the delimitation provisions in the Constitution amendment bill in Parliament, asserting that they were not against women's reservation but opposed to the "politically motivated" manner in which the bill was being brought.

All Opposition parties want a one-third reservation for women. They want it implemented based on the current Lok Sabha strength of 543 for the 2029 general election, Ramesh told reporters after the meeting.

Top Opposition leaders met at Kharge's residence to discuss a joint strategy on the bills brought for the implementation of the women's quota law and delimitation. Besides Kharge and Rahul Gandhi, the other leaders at the meeting included DMK's T R Baalu, the RJD's Tejashwi Yadav, Trinamool Congress's Sagarika Ghosh, Shiv Sena (UBT) leaders Sanjay Raut and Arvind Sawant, and the NCP-SCP's Supriya Sule, with Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav joining virtually. CPI leader Annie Raja, CPI-M's Nilotpal Basu, AAP leader Sanjay Singh, and Independent MP Kapil Sibal also attended. IUML's E T Mohammed Bashir and RSP's N K Premachandran were present. Congress general secretaries K C Venugopal and Jairam Ramesh attended as well.

The treasury and Opposition benches are rallying support at the Centre as well as in states amid concerns in the southern part of the country, including Tamil Nadu, that a delimitation exercise under the provisions of the bill would reduce their political standing because of a better performance on population control. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and senior DMK leader M K Stalin and the Telangana CM Congress's A Revanth Reddy sharpened their attack on the Centre over the issue of delimitation. Stalin has warned of a "massive agitation" if the state is harmed, and his Telangana counterpart is flagging "injustice".

Reddy has written an open letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging him to convene an all-party meeting to deliberate on the proposed delimitation, alleging that an increase in Lok Sabha seats based on pro rata, without considering economic contribution, would lead to a distortion in the country's federal balance.

Reddy has also written to his counterparts

from Andhra Pradesh (Chandrababu Naidu), Karnataka (Siddaramaiah), Kerala (Pinarayi Vijayan), Puducherry (N Rangasamy) and Tamil Nadu, calling for collective engagement among southern states to ensure that their concerns are articulated effectively at the national level.

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan alleged that delimitation could undermine the federal structure and adversely affect states like Kerala. The Government is executing a "devious plot" to usher in delimitation under the cover of women's reservation, TMC leader Derek O'Brien charged. In a social media post, Rahul Gandhi alleged that the Government's proposed amendments to the Constitution constitute an "attempted power grab" through the use of delimitation and gerrymandering. The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha emphasised that his party would not permit southern, northeastern, northwestern, and smaller states to be treated unfairly.

"We will not allow 'Hissa Chori' from OBC, Dalit and Adivasi communities by ignoring the caste census data. We will also not allow Southern, North Eastern, North Western and smaller states to be treated unfairly," Rahul said.

Lok Sabha seats will be increased to a maximum of 850 from the current 543 to "operationalise" the women's reservation law before the 2029 parliamentary polls, following a delimitation exercise to be carried out on the basis of the last published census.

According to the draft Constitution amendment bill, which will be introduced and is expected to be passed in the upcoming special sitting of Parliament, seats would also be increased in state and Union territory assemblies to accommodate 33 per cent reservation for women. Amending the Constitution requires a special majority in both Houses of Parliament: a majority of the total membership (more than 50 per cent) and a two-thirds majority of members present and voting. So if all 540 members, who are in the House currently, are present and voting, the two-thirds majority mark would be 360. The total strength of the NDA in the Lok Sabha stands at 292, while the major Opposition parties have 233 MPs.

The proposal includes increasing Lok Sabha seats from the current 543 to up to 850 to "operationalise" the women's reservation law ahead of the 2029 parliamentary elections, following a delimitation exercise based on the last published census. According to the draft Constitution amendment bill to be introduced in Parliament, seats in state and Union territory assemblies would also be increased to ensure 33 per cent reservation for women.

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) was quick to question the timing of the raid and did not mince words in accusing



this as a classic political vendetta, especially with the Punjab Assembly polls on the horizon.

The chasm between Chaddha and Arvind Kejriwal

Chadha's ouster may strengthen short-term loyalty around Kejriwal, but it signals deeper churn. Ambitious leaders chafe under a one-man dominance, and Punjab remains a battleground where local satraps like Mittal could prove vital.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

“Traditionally, Class 10 results are announced in



Students cheer after the declaration of Class 10th board results of Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) in Prayagraj on Wednesday PT

While 55,368 students have

The lowest pass percentage has been recorded by the Guwahati region (85.32 per cent). Delhi achieved a pass percentage of 97.38 per cent.

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
 ■ New Delhi

According to the National LWE Policy of the MHA, a Legacy and Thrust district is one that is now completely free of Naxal insurgency but requires sustained security measures and developmental initiatives to prevent any resurgence.



to ensure that the roots of discontent never resurface. This declaration not only closes a painful chapter in India's internal security history but also opens a new era of hope for thousands of families in the once-troubled heartlands of central and eastern India.





OUR CENSUS OUR DEVELOPMENT



Delhi
(New Delhi Municipal Council
& Delhi Cantonment Board)

Houselisting & Housing Census
16th April to 15th May

Delhi
(Municipal Corporation of Delhi)

Houselisting & Housing Census
16th May to 14th June

What will you be asked?



Information of house:

- Building number
- Materials of the floor, walls & ceiling
- Ascertain use of house- (Residential/ Non-residential)
- Condition of house

Others:

- Main Cereal consumed
- Mobile number (Only for Census communication)

Basic information about family:

- Number of family members
- Name, sex, caste of the head of the family (SC/ST or others)
- Ownership status of the house
- Number of rooms
- Number of married couples living in the house

Amenities:

- Source of drinking water
- Availability of drinking water source
- Main source of lighting
- Access to latrine
- Type of latrine
- Waste water outlet
- Bathroom facilities
- Kitchen & LPG/PNG connection
- Main fuel used for cooking

Assets:

- Radio/Transistors
- Television
- Access to Internet Computer/Laptop
- Mobile phone /Telephone
- Two-wheeler/ four-wheeler

» This stage lays the foundation for population enumeration

» All your information will remain completely confidential and secure

Let us fulfill our responsibility and participate in the Census



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States Focus



MAMATA CLAIMS CENTRAL FORCES TRIED TO SEARCH HER CAR

A day after the TMC alleged that the Election Commission of India (ECI) had ordered 'intrusive checks' of vehicles of its leaders, West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday claimed that central forces tried to search her car when she was travelling to Kolkata airport earlier in the day. Addressing a poll rally in Uttar Dinajpur district, Banerjee also accused the central ministers of "bringing in money" to the poll-bound State and "misusing their positions". "Central forces tried to check my car when I was going to the Kolkata airport today. If you have the guts, you check my car every day," she said.



MODI LEADS MEGA ROADSHOW IN TAMIL NADU; PREDICTS NDA WIN

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday held a well-attended roadshow here in support of NDA candidates for the April 23 Assembly polls in Tamil Nadu and asserted that the AIADMK-led alliance "will win for sure," while the ruling DMK will be shown the door in the hustings. Joined by AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami, BJP State president Nainar Nagenthiran, his predecessor K Annamalai and local BJP leader and former Union minister Pon Radhakrishnan, Modi stood on top of a decorated vehicle and waved at and greeted a good number of people who had lined up on either side of the road here in Kanyakumari district.

Women's quota bill a disguise to rob South India's rights: DMK's Maran



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

DMK leader Dayanidhi Maran on Wednesday claimed that the BJP Government at the Centre was using the women's reservation amendment bill as a disguise to ensure the delimitation and thereby take away the rights of the southern States. The BJP, which was "non-existent" in Tamil Nadu, can't expect respect for taking away the rights of the southern States, Maran, who represents Chennai Central constituency in the Lok Sabha, said. "We requested the people of Tamil Nadu to hoist black flags from their houses tomorrow to show their dissent (to delimitation) and the way Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah and the BJP are trying to ruin the country. With the disguise of women's reservation amendment bill, Modi is trying to bring the delimitation and attempting to take away the rights of the southern states," Maran said.

TVK chief Vijay to contest from Perambur and Tiruchirappalli East

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Perambur Assembly constituency in Chennai and Tiruchirappalli East have turned into high-profile constituencies in the run-up to April 23 election to Tamil Nadu Assembly as actor-politician Vijay has opted to contest from both the seats. Vijay, heading the Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK), is not the first leader to choose two constituencies to contest. In 1991, J Jayalalithaa contested from Bargur and



TVK chief and candidate from the Tiruchirappalli East constituency, Vijay, during a roadshow ahead of the Assembly elections in Chennai

West Bengal destroyed by TMC: Nirmala Sitharaman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kalna (West Bengal)

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday alleged that several welfare schemes introduced by the Narendra Modi Government have not reached the people of West Bengal owing to the Mamata Banerjee dispensation's reluctance to allow their implementation in the State. She said among the schemes the people of the State are being deprived of are Ayushman Bharat, PM Kisan and Awaas Yojana. "An atmosphere of terror has been created in the State by the TMC. West Bengal has been destroyed by the party," the finance minister said. "Your money was ready in

Delhi, but the TMC Government has not allowed that to be spent here," she claimed. Accusing the TMC dispensation of indulging in financial irregularities during the implementation of several schemes, she claimed that only being part of syndicates of the ruling party can assure one of the benefits in West Bengal. "The poor people of the State are not getting the benefits of free ration given by the Centre under the PDS scheme, but the State's minister is eating away with the funds meant for it," she said. Sitharaman said scams like school jobs and PDS (Public Distribution System) have taken place in the State, leading to the arrest of former ministers Partha Chatterjee and Jyotipriya Mallick by



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman during an event organised for local weavers at Kalna in Purba Bardhaman on Wednesday

central investigating agencies. Both are currently out on bail. "Even funds under the midday meal scheme for the students were misappropriated by using bogus names of beneficiaries," she alleged, while addressing a cotton

weavers' conference of the BJP's handloom and weaver cell at Kalna in Purba Bardhaman district. The minister said that under the TMC rule in West Bengal, people have to give money to syndicates to get

every work done or receive benefits of welfare schemes. "A BJP Government in the State will ensure people receive benefits of all central welfare schemes, along with new schemes the new Government will roll out," she said. The finance minister asserted that "syndicate raj will be ended in the State". Stating that around 3.7 lakh people in West Bengal are involved in handloom saree production, Sitharaman said this is an asset which should be incentivised and given all kinds of assistance, "but the TMC Government provides them with no support". Sitharaman said that powerlooms and the import of cotton sarees from countries like Bangladesh are a challenge to the handloom

industry in the State. She said that in West Bengal, there has been a reduction in handlooms by about 60 per cent, while daily earnings have dropped by over 50 per cent. "But I want to assure you that this situation will change," she said, asserting that the BJP will win the 2026 assembly elections in the State by defeating the Trinamool Congress. She said the Prime Minister Viswakarma Yojana will benefit the weavers, but the Mamata Banerjee Government is denying people its benefits. She said the 'Chai Srameek Protsahan Yojana', which can benefit over three lakh tea garden workers in north Bengal, was not implemented by the TMC Government.

PM Modi urges nine collective pledges for developed Karnataka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mandya (Karnataka)

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday appealed to people to take nine collective pledges, ranging from water conservation, natural farming, to fitness and service, to realise a "developed Karnataka and a developed India". Listing his priorities, Modi said his first request is about water conservation and better water management, followed by appeals for tree plantation under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' (One tree in the name of mother) campaign, cleanliness in public and religious places, strengthening local products through "Vocal for Local," promoting domestic tourism, adopting chemical-free natural farming, encouraging healthy



PM Narendra Modi greeting the gathering during the inauguration of the Guru Bhairavaikya Mandira of Adichunchanagiri Math in Mandya district, Karnataka

eating with millets and reduced oil consumption. Modi also urged people to embrace yoga and fitness, and to nurture service. "If we move forward with honesty and determination on these nine resolutions, we can rapidly progress towards a developed Karnataka and a developed India," he said while addressing an event

organised to inaugurate Sri Guru Bhairavaikya Mandira at the Adichunchanagiri Mahasamsthana Math in Mandya. The Mandira is a memorial dedicated to the revered seer, Sri Balagangad haranatha Mahaswami, the 71st Pontiff of the Math, revered by the dominant Vokkaliga community.

ECI to deploy 2,407 CAPF companies for West Bengal polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Election Commission of India (ECI) will deploy 2,407 companies of central armed police forces for the first phase of the West Bengal Assembly polls on April 23, with the highest number of personnel likely to be deployed for the Murshidabad district, a senior official said on Wednesday. Elections to the 294-member West Bengal Assembly will be held in two phases - on April 23 and April 29. Votes will be counted on May 4. The official said Murshidabad is likely to have the highest deployment with 316 companies of forces, including 240 in the Murshidabad police district and 76 in Jangipur. Murshidabad has been witness to several incidents of violence in recent years, including clashes linked to protests over the Waqf Act and unrest during the NRC agitation. "Altogether 2,407 companies of central forces are being deployed in the first phase. The allocation has been made following a detailed vulnerability assessment to ensure voters can exercise their franchise without



fear," the EC official said. Purba Medinipur district is likely to see the second-highest deployment with 273 companies, he said, adding that the district is being closely watched due to the politically crucial Nandigram seat, where Leader of Opposition Suwendu Adhikari is in the fray. The Commission has divided Uttar Dinajpur into two police districts, with 61 companies earmarked for Islampur and 71 for Raiganj, he said. Among other key deployments, 125 companies will likely be stationed in the Asansol-Durgapur Police Commissionerate and 44 in the Siliguri Police Commissionerate. In north Bengal, Darjeeling is likely to have 61 companies, Kalimpong 21, Jalpaiguri 92 and Alipurduar 77, the official said.

BJP vows 33% govt job quota for Bengal women: Smriti Irani

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior BJP leader Smriti Irani on Wednesday pitched for early implementation of the 33 per cent women's reservation law, while accusing Opposition parties of "double standards" and reiterating her party's commitment to women's empowerment in West Bengal with a promise of similar quotas in Government jobs. The law providing for one-third reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies is yet to be operationalised as its rollout is



Leader of Opposition in the West Bengal Assembly Suwendu Adhikari, and former BJP MP Smriti Irani during the launch of 'Matri Shakti Guarantee' card in Kolkata on Wednesday

linked to the completion of a fresh Census and subsequent delimitation exercise, a key point of contention

between the ruling NDA and Opposition parties. Responding to a question, Irani said the BJP-led

Government under Prime Minister Narendra Modi has demonstrated its resolve on women's empowerment through legislative action. She accused Opposition parties of "speaking in multiple tongues" despite having had past opportunities to enact the reforms when they were in power. Opposition parties, including the Congress, have supported the principle of reservation, but questioned the delay in implementation, arguing that linking it to delimitation could push its rollout to the next general elections after 2029.

Against this backdrop, Irani said the BJP remains committed to expanding women's participation in governance and public life, highlighting complementary initiatives in financial inclusion, health-care and livelihood support. Turning to West Bengal, she said the party would replicate its national commitment at the state level if voted to power. She announced that 33 per cent reservation would be provided to women in Government jobs in the State, alongside direct financial assistance and other welfare measures.

BJP will seal borders and drive out infiltrators: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday said that while the Election Commission of India (ECI) has only removed infiltrators from the electoral rolls of West Bengal, the larger task would be to drive them out of the country's borders. Sharpening his anti-infiltration pitch during campaigns for the upcoming Assembly elections in Bengal, Shah said once the BJP forms a Government in the State, it will "seal the country's eastern borders in such a manner that even birds won't be able to flap their wings" around the fences. "Didi (Mamata Banerjee) doesn't want to give 600

acres of land to the BSF required to build the border fences. We have decided that once we have a BJP chief minister here, we will complete the task of fencing within 45 days on the required land," Shah told a gathering at Tufangunj in the Bangladesh-bordering Cooch Behar district of north Bengal. "And it's not just about stopping outsiders from coming in. It's also about those who have already infiltrated. While the ECI has only removed infiltrators from the electoral rolls of West Bengal, the larger task would be to drive them out of the country's borders," he added. Nearly 91 lakh names have been deleted by the ECI from



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during a rally ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in Raiganj

the State's voters' lists during the recently concluded SIR exercise, triggering a major political dust-up in the run-up to the polls, with the TMC accusing the commission of acting at the behest of the BJP. The Union home minister

has been staying put in Bengal over the past few days and has held multiple rallies across the State in the run-up to the April 23 polls, when voters in north Bengal districts would exercise their franchise, sharpening the infiltration issue as one of the

most prominent poll planks of the BJP. Accusing Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of having a "step-motherly attitude" towards north Bengal, Shah said that her priorities lay elsewhere. "Of the ₹4 lakh crore total State Budget, she gave ₹5,700 crore to Muslims, but allotted only ₹1,200 crore for the entire north Bengal region," he said. Shah announced the inclusion of the Rajbanshi language in the Constitution's 8th schedule and the setting up of a Narayani battalion, in honour of the community's erstwhile Narayani Sena militia, in the State reserve police force once the BJP forms a Government in Bengal.

Siddaramaiah urges PM to resolve 18 pending State issues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Wednesday submitted a memorandum to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeking his intervention on 18 issues, including the demand to give constitutional protection to Karnataka's 56 per cent reservation policy and release of deficit grants, among others. Siddaramaiah also highlighted that recurring delays on the part of the Union Government, in approvals



PM Narendra Modi being received by Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah upon his arrival at the airport in Bengaluru

and fund releases to the State, have created a perception of systemic inequity. CM sought the PM's intervention for the inclusion of

Karnataka's 56 per cent reservation for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes in the Ninth Schedule of the Constitution

and inclusion of certain OBCs in the central list of ST. He insisted on the release of revenue deficit grants, special grants to Bengaluru, and approval to the Makedatu project, among others. According to the chief minister's office, Siddaramaiah handed over the memorandum to the prime minister on his arrival at the city's HAL airport on his way to Adichunchanagiri in Mandya district. "Karnataka has always taken pride in contributing to India's growth with responsibility and vision. However, recurring delays in approvals and

financial releases have created a perception of systemic inequity. Addressing these concerns will reaffirm the spirit of true cooperative federalism and strengthen our shared vision for the development of India," Siddaramaiah said in the letter to Modi. "The people of Karnataka look forward to your kind intervention in resolving these issues. I am certain that the Union Government will enable Karnataka to continue playing a transformative role in India's inclusive and sustainable development," he said.

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Order Order

Varanasi court acquits MLA, MLC in 24-year-old former MP attack case

A special MP-MLA court on Wednesday acquitted all six accused, including Ayodhya MLA Abhay Singh and MLC Vineet Singh, in a 24-year-old Nadesar shootout case involving former Jaunpur MP Dhananjay Singh.

Dhananjay, his gunner Vasudev Pandey, and driver Dinesh Kumar Gupta were injured in the 2002 attack. Special Judge Yajurvendra Vikram Singh acquitted the accused, citing insufficient evidence and granting them the benefit of doubt. The court also acquitted Sanjay Singh Raghuvanshi, Satyendra alias Bablu Singh, Sandeep Singh alias Pappu, and Vinod Singh.

Abhay Singh was elected MLA in 2022 on a Samajwadi Party ticket. He was expelled by the party in 2025 for anti-party activities.

According to the prosecution, the incident occurred on October 4, 2002, in the Nadesar area.

Dhananjay, then an MLA, was returning to Jaunpur from Varanasi in a car when the accused intercepted him near Taksal Cinema.



Jal Jeevan scam: Subodh Agarwal sent to 14-day judicial custody

A court here on Wednesday sent retired IAS officer Subodh Agarwal, who was arrested in connection with the alleged ₹960-crore Jal Jeevan Mission scam, to 14-day judicial custody.

Agarwal was arrested on April 10 and was under police custody. Anti Corruption Bureau (ACB) produced him before an ACB court on completion of the remand period.

The court rejected ACB's request for police custody and remanded Agarwal to judicial custody.

Talking to reporters outside the court, Agarwal's lawyer Vedant Sharma claimed that four tenders came during Agarwal's tenure while 33 tenders were related to the tenure of his predecessor and should be investigated. A team from the ACB arrested Agarwal on Thursday last week in connection with the case.

Some firms had allegedly secured tenders by submitting forged completion certificates in connivance with officers.

Last month, the ACB arrested nine persons, including senior engineers and retired officials, in connection with the scam. Earlier, the ACB had arrested contractors.



Delhi HC permits IVF procedure for Indian army soldier in vegetative state

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has permitted the continuation of IVF procedure for an Army soldier, who is in a persistent vegetative state with no foreseeable scope of neurological recovery in the near future.

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav stated that the soldier's earlier consent, which was given when he started the IVF procedure, was sufficient even at this stage, and the consent of the wife would be treated as valid consent on his behalf for



the purposes of the Assisted Reproductive Technology (Regulation) Act.

The court passed the order on a petition by the wife of the personnel, who sought directions for extraction and cryopreservation of her husband's genetic material



Trouble for Robert Vadra in Shikohpur land deal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Wednesday took cognisance of an Enforcement Directorate chargesheet against businessman Robert Vadra in a money laundering case linked to a land deal in Haryana's Shikohpur.

Special Judge Sushant Changotra directed Vadra and the other accused in the case to appear before it on May 16.

A reasoned order is awaited.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) filed the

chargesheet against Vadra, husband of Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, last July.

It was the first time that any probe agency filed a chargesheet against 57-year-old Vadra in a criminal case. In April 2025, the ED had questioned Vadra for three consecutive days.

The probe against Vadra is linked to a land deal at Manesar-Shikohpur (now Sector 83) in Haryana's Gurugram district.

The deal was done in February 2008 by a company named Skylight Hospitality



Pvt Ltd, where Vadra was a director earlier, under which it purchased a 3.5-acre land in Shikohpur from Onkareshwar Properties for ₹7.5 crore.

At the time, Haryana was ruled by the Congress led by Bhupinder Singh Hooda. Four years later, in September 2012, the company sold the land to realty major DLF for ₹58 crore.

The deal got embroiled in controversy in October 2012 after IAS officer Ashok Khemka, then posted as director general of land consolidation and land records-cum-inspector-general of reg-

istration, cancelled the mutation after categorising the transaction as violative of the state consolidation act and some related procedures.

Vadra has been denying any wrongdoing, calling the case a "political vendetta" against him and his family, including former Congress president Sonia Gandhi and Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi.

The ED is also investigating Vadra in two other cases, including one against UK-based arms consultant Sanjay Bhandari, and a land deal in Rajasthan's Bikaner.

Justice Sharma's children empanelled as Govt lawyers: Kerjiwal in HC on recusal plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Seeking recusal of Delhi High Court judge Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal has claimed in an affidavit that the judge's children are empanelled Central Government lawyers who receive work through solicitor general Tushar Mehta who appeared for the CBI.

Kejriwal, in an additional affidavit filed in relation to his application seeking Justice Sharma to withdraw from hearing the probe agency's

Judge hold multiple live Central Government panel engagements and receive Government work through the same legal establishment and law officer, the apprehension becomes direct, grave and impossible for me to ignore," the affidavit dated April 14 claimed.

Relying on documents in the public domain, including information received under the RTI mechanism, Kejriwal alleged that substantial legal work was allocated to Justice Sharma's son.

"The RTI reply reported that the said social media post also



petition against his discharge in the liquor policy case, said there was a "direct conflict of interest", which "amplified" his apprehension and constituted grounds for recusal.

He also prayed for time to make further oral and rejoiner submissions, fearing that continuing the case before Justice Sharma might not carry the "full appearance of judicial detachment, independence and neutrality that the law requires".

"(In) a criminal case of this nature, where the prosecuting agency is the CBI, where the Central Government's highest law officers appear against me, and where the immediate family members of the Hon'ble

mentioned that a total of 2,487 cases were marked to the son of the Hon'ble Justice in the year 2023; 1,784 cases in 2024 and 1,633 cases in 2025," the affidavit submitted.

Kejriwal said he learnt about these "material facts" after filing the recusal application and emphasised that empanelment by the central Government was not honorary but involved court appearances and financial benefit.

In the affidavit, he further submitted that when Justice Sharma reserved verdict on the recusal application on April 13 after holding court till 7 pm, he was not given a fair and reasonable opportunity to make rejoinder submissions.

Courts can't sit in judgement in matters of religious belief of denomination: TDB to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB), which manages the historic Sabarimala temple in Kerala, told the Supreme Court on Wednesday that religion is a set of beliefs and practices followed by a denomination with a broadly similar identity and the court cannot sit in judgement of that belief.

A nine-judge Constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant was told by the board, which is a statutory autonomous body that manages over 1,000 temples in South India, that the beliefs and practices of the community have to be judged by the subjective belief of the community and the court is bound to accept their belief.



Senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the TDB said, "Religion is a set of beliefs and practices followed by a group/sect/denomination with a broadly similar identity. While Article 25 clearly vests in an individual the right to profess, practice and propagate religion, such individual rights cannot be allowed to extend to an area

which intrudes upon the mass of individual rights of all other adherents of that religion or denomination."

The bench also comprising Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan, and Joymalya Bagchi was told by Singhvi that it is impermissible to

CJI hails achievements of outgoing SC judge Rajesh Bindal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday hailed the achievements of outgoing Supreme Court judge Justice Rajesh Bindal saying he did not merely performed the "adjudicatory role" as a judge, but also discharged the institutional functions with integrity and had an unparalleled case disposal rate.

Born on April 16, 1961, in Ambala, Justice Bindal began his legal career in 1985 after earning his law degree from the Kurukshetra University and was elevated as a judge of the Punjab and Haryana



SC judge Rajesh Bindal

High Court in 2006. He then went on to serve in multiple high courts, including the Jammu and Kashmir HC, Calcutta HC, and Allahabad HC, where he also held positions as the chief justice.

Justice Bindal, who was at number 14 in the seniority, was elevated to the top court on February 13, 2023 and demitting office on April 15, 2026 with over three year tenure in which he authored over 100 judgements.

With Justice Bindal's retirement, the total number of vacancies in the top court, having 34 sanctioned posts of judges, becomes two.

Heading the ceremonial bench, which comprised justices Bindal and Joymalya Bagchi, the CJI recalled his decades-long association with the outgoing judge from his advocacy days.

Delhi court convicts Shahtoosh shawl trader in wildlife crime case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court convicted a Jaipur art gallery owner for attempting to illegally export Shahtoosh wool shawls, made from the underfur of the critically endangered Tibetan Antelope, in violation of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, an Environment ministry official said on Wednesday. The chief judicial magistrate at Rouse Avenue District Courts delivered the judgment against Syed Shahid Ahmed Kashani, owner of Indian Art Gallery, Jaipur, on March 12, bringing to a close a case that surfaced in December 2008.

"The Tibetan Antelope, locally known as Chiru, is listed in Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, and its trade is strictly prohibited under domestic law. The Shahtoosh shawl trade has also been banned globally since 1975 under the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES), to which India is a signatory," said an official.

Gujarat HC issues notices to Meta, X, Google over PIL seeking curb on misuse of AI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat High Court has issued notices to technology firms Meta India, Google, X, Reddit and Scribd over a PIL seeking formulation of a robust regulatory mechanism to curb the misuse of artificial intelligence (AI) in generating and circulating deep-fake videos and photographs.

While issuing notices to them returnable on May 8, a division bench of Chief Justice Sunita Agarwal and Justice DN Ray also directed the respondent intermediaries to ensure they are brought onboard the Sahyog



portal for better coordination and time-bound action related to take-down of unlawful contents in strict compliance of the provisions of the

Rules of the Information Technology Act, 2000.

"Effective and meaningful responses/action of the respondent intermediaries will be key to the due diligence obligations enforced upon them under the statutory framework," the court noted in an order passed recently and made available this week.

In their affidavits, the central and Gujarat Governments informed the court about frequent delays, repeated procedural obligations and non-compliance by certain tech platforms to lawful notices issued to them.

SC stays Telangana HC order granting one-week transit anticipatory bail to Pawan Khera

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a setback to Congress leader Pawan Khera, the Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed the Telangana High Court order granting him one-week transit anticipatory bail in a case registered for levelling allegations against Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife.

A bench of Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar issued notice to Khera and others seeking their responses on the plea filed by the Assam Government challenging the Telangana High Court's April 10 order.

"Considering all the aspects, issue notice. In the

meantime, operation of the impugned order shall remain stayed," the bench said.

It made clear that in case Khera applies for anticipatory bail before the court having jurisdiction in Assam, the order passed by the apex court would not have any adverse inference while deciding such a plea.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Assam Government, argued that it was a case of lack of territorial jurisdiction and no averment was there in Khera's plea as to why he had moved the Telangana High Court.

"The offence is committed in Assam. The FIR is registered in Assam," Mehta said, adding that it was a "forum choosing".



Congress leader Pawan Khera

"This is complete abuse of the process. He (Khera) does not say why he is not going to Assam and why he can't go to Assam," the top law officer said while seeking a stay on the high court order.

Mehta said the high court had missed that one of the

offences alleged against Khera was punishable with a sentence of up to 10 years.

The bench observed that during the hearing before the high court, Khera had submitted a note stating that his wife was staying at Hyderabad.

Mehta said as per the address mentioned in the Aadhaar card, his wife was shown to be residing in Delhi.

He questioned whether merely having some property, whether owned or rented, confers jurisdiction as someone can buy or rent 10 properties in 10 different places.

Mehta said "this would be a case of forum choosing", which was frowned upon by the apex court in some of its judgements.

The bench observed that Khera has also filed an application seeking extension of anticipatory bail by three weeks.

The top court, while issuing notice on the plea, posted it for hearing after three weeks. With the staying of the

high court's order granting relief to Khera, the Assam police may take coercive action against the Congress leader in the case.

On April 10, the high court had granted one-week transit anticipatory bail to Khera with certain conditions and gave him a week to file an application before the court concerned.

The Congress leader had, on April 5, in a press conference alleged that Assam CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, has multiple passports and foreign property, which were not declared in the chief minister's election affidavit for the April 9 Assembly polls in that State.

The Sarmas had rejected the allegations as false and fabricated.

The case against Khera was registered at the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station under several sections of the BNS sections, including 175 (false statement in connection with an election), 35 (Right of private defence of the body and of property) and 318 (cheating).

"Without expressing any opinion on the merits of the case, this court is of the view that the petitioner has made out a case for the grant of limited transit anticipatory bail, as his apprehension of arrest appears to be reasonable and supported by material on record," the high court had said in its order.

The conditions were that the petitioner shall be released on bail in the event of arrest on his executing a

personal bond for ₹one lakh with two sureties for the like sum each, cooperate with the investigation and make himself available for interrogation as and when required by the investigating officer and that he shall not leave the country without prior permission of the competent court.

The conditions further include that the petitioner shall, within the stipulated period, approach the competent jurisdictional court in Assam and seek appropriate relief and he, being a public figure, shall exercise restraint in making any further public statements in relation to the subject matter of the present case, which may prejudice the investigation, the order said.



Editor's
TAKE

Samrat Choudhary and Bihar's political pivot

Nitish Kumar's exit opens the door to a new phase in Bihar politics, as the Bharatiya Janata Party steps out of the shadows to lead from the front for the first time

Bihar politics has taken a definitive shift as Nitish Kumar, who remained the fulcrum of Bihar politics, has left state politics to be active in national politics. His departure ends an era where Nitish Kumar remained the pivot of Bihar politics, and no government could be imagined without him. It also marks the beginning of the Bharatiya Janata Party to lead from the front.

The Bihar politics has always been defined by caste. Any party that wants its presence in the state must ensure that it has understood the caste matrix of the State. In Samrat Choudhary the BJP has got it right. He belongs to the Kushwaha caste which is a prominent Other Backwards Class (OBC) group in Bihar making him an OBC leader that would be acceptable for the large section of population. He happens to be the son of veteran Bihar politician Shakuni Choudhary and his caste along with Nitish Kumar's, community (Koeri-Kurmi) is viewed as a crucial voting bloc. The BJP has carefully tried to balance the delicate caste equations.

Choudhary's appointment is historic as he is the first leader from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to become the chief minister of Bihar. While the BJP has long been present as part of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in the State, it played a supporting role for a long time. This transition reflects the party's growing confidence in Bihar.

At 57, Choudhary represents a blend of political inheritance and personal ambition. He was a part of Rashtriya Janata Dal and Janata Dal (United), before he joined the BJP in 2017. Since then, his rise has been swift as he soon assumed the leadership of the party's Bihar unit, then became deputy chief minister, and now the candidate for the top post of the State. Interestingly, his vow to retain his saffron turban until Nitish Kumar was unseated, and offering in Ayodhya, underscored his combative style. Moreover, as he comes from a prominent OBC caste – the Koeri-Kushwaha community – his electoral appeal in a caste-sensitive state would be high.

For Bihar this could be a turning point. On one hand, Choudhary's elevation signals a generational shift and the possibility of a more assertive governance model backed by the Centre. It could bring greater policy alignment with the Centre, potentially accelerating infrastructure, investment, and welfare initiatives. On the other hand, it places the burden of delivery on a leader who must now move beyond political mobilisation to administrative effectiveness. But the challenges are equally daunting. Choudhary will have to deliver as it is going to be a 'double-engine' government. Bihar remains an underdeveloped state with issues of unemployment, industrial stagnation, and gaps in education and healthcare to be taken care of. Choudhary must come up with a development agenda that is both inclusive and forward-looking, while maintaining the delicate social balance. Ultimately, Samrat Choudhary's appointment is more than a routine change of guard – it is a signal of Bihar's evolving political identity. The big question is if Samrat Choudhary can deliver while retaining his position in the party.

Delimitation: A constitutional necessity

The renewed debate over women's reservation, triggered by Sonia Gandhi's recent intervention, reveals less a disagreement over principle and more a clash over political narratives



TUHIN A
SINHA

The debate sparked by Sonia Gandhi's recent article on women's reservation reflects a familiar pattern in Indian policymaking – where long-overdue structural reforms are questioned less on substance and more on process. A closer reading of the criticism directed at the Modi government suggests that much of it rests on mischaracterisation rather than fact.

Delimitation as 'the real issue': A flawed premise

The attempt to frame delimitation as the "real issue", distinct from women's reservation, is fundamentally misplaced. Delimitation is not a political choice but a constitutional necessity, intended to ensure that representation reflects current demographic realities. Periodic recalibration of constituencies is intrinsic to democratic fairness. To argue that linking women's reservation with this process creates uncertainty is to overlook this constitutional logic. On the contrary, integrating women's reservation with delimitation ensures structural coherence. Implementing reservation on an outdated constituency framework would risk distortion and imbalance. Aligning the two processes strengthens institutional credibility and ensures that representation is both fair and contemporary.

The charge of "politicisation" is equally unconvincing. The Indian National Congress itself presided over years of indecision on women's reservation and failed to bring any clarity to delimitation-related questions. To now describe a structured approach as "uncertain" appears less like concern and more like retrospective justification.

At its core, delimitation is about fairness. Integrating women's reservation into this exercise is not distortion – it is alignment with its purpose. Since delimitation is historically tied to census cycles to ensure accuracy, embedding reservation within this framework ensures that the reform is meaningful and durable rather than symbolic. What is being portrayed as a tactic is, in reality, a constitutionally sound and administratively efficient approach.

Decisiveness versus delay

The allegation that the government is acting in haste does not withstand scrutiny. Women's reservation is not a sudden policy initiative; it is a reform that has remained pending for decades. Successive governments debated it



but failed to implement it. What is being witnessed now is not speed, but the translation of long-standing intent into action. To label this as haste is to invert reality. Decisive governance may appear abrupt to those accustomed to prevarication, but that does not make it procedurally flawed.

While consultation remains important, over-consultation cannot become a pretext for paralysis. Democracies require a balance between discussion and decision. Endless consensus-building, without closure, undermines public trust in governance. At some point, leadership must move from dialogue to delivery and that is precisely what is happening. The broader approach reflects a governance model anchored in clarity and momentum. A country of India's scale cannot afford to indefinitely delay transformative reforms in pursuit of perfect agreement. Progress inevitably demands a degree of decisiveness.

Census delays: Context matters

Concerns around the delayed Census must be understood in context. The disruption caused by the pandemic affected large-scale administrative exercises worldwide. India's delay is part of a broader global pattern, not an isolated lapse. Crucially, the commitment to conduct the Census remains firm. The process has been deferred, not abandoned. When dealing with a foundational exercise that informs policy, representation, and resource allocation, accuracy must take precedence over speed.

A hurried Census-especially one involving complex data considerations-would risk compromising its credibility. Reliable data is essential for legitimate outcomes. Ensuring that integrity is maintained is not administrative hesitation; it is responsible governance.

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The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Federal balance concerns: Premature anxieties

The argument that delimitation could shift the balance of power among states is, at this stage, purely speculative. It projects hypothetical outcomes onto a process that is governed by constitutional principles and institutional safeguards. Delimitation is not an arbitrary exercise; it is designed to ensure equitable representation based on current realities. Suggesting that it will inherently disadvantage certain states risks undermining trust in the very mechanisms that sustain democratic balance. Reforms of this nature cannot be indefinitely stalled due to hypothetical fears. While concerns can be discussed, they cannot become a veto against progress. The focus must remain on ensuring fair representation, not on conjectural political outcomes.

It is also evident that such arguments shift attention away from the core reform-women's representation – and towards peripheral uncertainties. This risks creating confusion and diluting the significance of a long-pending change.

The role of Parliament

Calls for greater deliberation would carry more weight if avenues for debate were unavailable. In reality, the government has convened a special session of Parliament, providing the highest democratic platform for discussion and scrutiny.

If the opposition is serious about engaging, Parliament is the appropriate forum. Raising objections outside while hesitating within raises questions about intent. Deliberation is essential, but so is decision-making. For decades, women's reservation remained stuck in discussion without implementation. What is unfolding now is a necessary shift-from prolonged debate to concrete action.

A democracy cannot function on perpetual indecision. It must balance consultation with closure. To resist decisions in the name of endless debate risks ensuring that no reform is ever realised. The present debate is not merely about procedural disagreement; it is about whether India is prepared to act on long-articulated commitments. Linking women's reservation with delimitation is not political manoeuvring but institutional alignment. Moving forward now is not haste, but overdue resolve. The criticism, therefore, appears less about safeguarding process and more about resisting momentum. But reforms of this scale cannot remain indefinitely deferred. They require clarity of intent and courage of execution. The Women's Reservation Bill and delimitation mark another manifestation of PM Modi's political willpower and decisive leadership-which were conspicuously absent in the UPA era.

A devotee's perspective on death



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Let us first understand what death actually is. Death is when a soul leaves its material body. Lord Krishna describes death in the Bhagavad Gita as a change of body in its eternal journey (2.13). Just as childhood, youth, and old age are changes in the body of a soul, death is a similar change. Devotees of God accept this as a positive change because they attain promotion. Such promotion is of three kinds. The first is taking birth in a family that is pure and prosperous (6.41). The next level is being born in a family of wise yogis (6.42). Such a birth is very rare in this world. The highest level is being liberated from the repeated cycle of birth and death in a material body (18.62).

Devotees do not fear death as non-devotees do, who consider it annihilation. Considering oneself as a mate-

rial body due to gross ignorance of reality is the reason for such fear. Devotees also realise that they have reached a good, better, or best position, as indicated earlier. The topmost devotees, like Swami Vivekananda, knew that they had reached the highest position in their life and were enjoying it. As one must leave the material body, this being the law of nature, they know that what is born must also die. If anything, they wish to leave their material body when they are at the peak of their life. They cannot imagine fearing and dying helplessly. If anything, they make the requisite preparations for leaving the body. They sense that when the life force reduces appreciably, God is indicating that it is time to leave the body, and they depart in full God consciousness.

They have also realised two more facts. The closure of life is essential; the material body cannot continue indefinitely. It deteriorates, making even the maintenance of the body very difficult. Personally speaking, I am forced to do many exercises to keep my different body organs and faculties healthy. The 'jara' (miseries of old age) are hard to bear, especially because they come in the way of doing 'bhakti' (devotion to God). The other reason I



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Such service is highly pleasing to God. What, then, is the conclusion? Fear of death can be reduced by these three steps. One, realise that I am a soul, not a material body, which must die; I will not. Two, I will attain a better birth because I am a good person. Third, one should take shelter of God and become a devotee.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Balance representation and stability

Appropriately "Government circulates Bills to increase Lok Sabha seats" (April 15), the proposal to raise the strength to 850 risks overcrowding, increased disruption, and regional imbalance, particularly disadvantaging southern states that have successfully controlled population growth.

Globally, electoral systems vary. India, the UK, the USA, and Canada follow the first-past-the-post system, which is simple but often distorts vote-to-seat ratios. Many European nations, Brazil, Chile, South Africa, and Israel use proportional representation, ensuring diversity but often leading to coalition governments. Countries like Germany, New Zealand, and Scotland adopt mixed-member proportional systems, balancing local accountability with proportional fairness. Additionally, expanding the Lok Sabha without strengthening the Rajya Sabha may create institutional imbalance. With 850 members, the Lower House could overwhelm the Upper House during joint sessions, weakening its revisory role. Enhancing the Rajya Sabha's strength and function is therefore essential. India's challenge lies not merely in numbers but in designing institutions that uphold fairness, discipline, and balance.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Food waste global crisis

It is distressing to note that 1.05 billion tonnes of food were wasted globally in 2022, with India emerging as the second-largest contributor, wasting nearly 78 million tonnes annually, according to the United Nations Environment Programme Food Waste Index Report 2024. This staggering wastage coexists with persistent hunger and malnutrition.

Scientists warn that by 2050, the global population may exceed 10 billion, potentially leading to severe food shortages.

Food waste has become a matter of urgent global concern. Governments and international organisations must work collectively to raise awareness and formulate effective policies to reduce food loss. Coordination across the food supply chain-farmers, handlers, processors, and traders – is equally essential. Collaboration between public and private sectors, along with civil society, can play a decisive role.

Public education is critical. People must be informed about safe food handling, proper storage, and the meaning of "best before" dates.

Discarding food is neither sustainable nor ethical. Protecting food resources is essential for ensuring environmental balance and future food security.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | TAMIL NADU

Reform with equity intact

The Constitution (136th Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeking to provide 33 per cent reservation for women and increase the number of Lok Sabha MPs, is long overdue.

The current strength of 543 seats presents an anomalous situation, where an MP from populous Uttar Pradesh may represent nearly 2 million people, while another from a southern state may represent about 1 million. To address this imbalance, the strength of the Lower House is proposed to be increased to around 850 MPs.

At the same time, the lower population growth in southern states reflects higher literacy levels and effective implementation of population control measures. These states must be encouraged, not penalised. They fear reduced leverage in fund allocation despite contributing more in taxes, along with a possible shift of political power towards the North.

However, abandoning the Bill entirely would be imprudent. A balanced solution lies in ensuring that no state loses its current representation, while also factoring in performance indicators such as literacy and tax contribution. Parliament must evolve with fairness, not remain status quoist.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

ASHA BHOSLE'S LEGACY OF RESILIENCE AND MUSICAL EVOLUTION

Appropriately "Jaaiee aap kahaan jaayenge..." (April 15, 2026), Asha Bhosle's passing reminds us that Indian music is inseparable from the resilience of its artists. She began her journey in an era when playback singers were often underpaid and rarely credited, yet she transformed adversity into enduring artistry. By refusing to be confined to stereotypical roles or mere dance numbers, she expanded the expressive vocabulary of Bollywood music, proving that versatility is not indulgence but a necessity for survival.

Her voice carried the innocence of early cinema while simultaneously embracing the rhythm and innovation of modernity, ensuring a seamless continuity across generations. Her legacy is not measured

solely in fame or financial success, but in her unwavering courage to evolve without compromising authenticity.

Today's singers benefit from royalties, digital platforms, and global recognition largely because pioneers like her fought silent battles for dignity and fair recognition. For listeners across decades, her songs were more than melodies-they were emotional anchors, accompanying moments of joy, longing, and reflection.

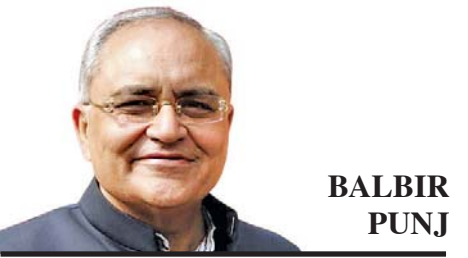
To honour her is to recognise that every equitable note in today's music industry rests upon the foundations she helped build. Her passing leaves behind both gratitude and an irreplaceable silence.

VEDA CHIDANAND | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Predatory Jihadis on the move: ‘Secularists’ in denial mode

A society that refuses to confront uncomfortable truths condemns itself to perpetual discord. If “secularism” is to retain any credibility, it must rest on intellectual honesty-recognising that communal tensions are not manufactured in a vacuum but are often sustained by denial masquerading as virtue



BALBIR PUNJ

One of the most enduring pastimes of India's self-styled 'secularists' is the relentless sermonising on Hindu-Muslim 'unity' or the importance of 'Ganga-Jamuni tehzeeb'. Yet, despite decades of such moral posturing, their project has yielded little beyond a bloody partition and rhetorical fatigue. Predictably, the blame is routinely shifted onto the RSS-BJP, accused of fuelling latent tensions. This diagnosis is not merely shallow-it is wilfully dishonest.

The very ideological fraternity that preaches harmony to society is often the first to brand a Hindu as 'bigoted' simply for exercising caution in selecting tenants based on past experiences or perceived risks. Yet, they turn a blind eye when far more alarming criminal activities surface-organised Muslim gangs systematically targeting Hindus to force them into converting to Islam. It's a regular phenomenon, threatening social harmony.

The recent case from Maharashtra's Nashik illustrates this troubling pattern. As the investigation expanded, more victims came forward, resulting in at least nine FIRs and the arrest of several accused individuals. Muslim men and women working at a business process outsourcing (BPO) unit linked to Tata Consultancy Services were pressuring Hindus, especially economically vulnerable women, to convert to Islam. The HR official Nida Khan, dubbed the "lady captain", has come under scrutiny amid allegations pointing to a deeply rotten nexus of workplace coercion and conversion-linked pressure.

This isn't an isolated case or an aberration-a result of some indiscretion by misguided individuals. It's an old tactic, rooted in theology, aimed at altering the demographics of the subcontinent. Such cases-either under investigation or judicial process-collectively indicate a common modus operandi involving deception, exploitation, and coercion.

In Lucknow, for instance, a son-father-mother trio-Dr Rameezuddin, Salimuddin, and Khateja-was booked for allegedly entrapping Hindu women, subjecting them to sexual exploitation, coercing abor-



EXTENDING THIS LINE OF ARGUMENT, CHRISTIAN C SAHNER, IN 'CHRISTIAN MARTYRS UNDER ISLAM: RELIGIOUS VIOLENCE AND THE MAKING OF THE MUSLIM WORLD', OBSERVES: "ISLAM SPREAD THROUGH THE CHRISTIAN WORLD VIA THE BEDROOM

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of 'Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India' and 'Narrative ka Mayajal'

dailypioneer @balbirpunj The Pioneer

tions, and exerting pressure for religious conversion.

A similarly troubling case has emerged from Dehradun in Uttarakhand, where a Muslim girl, Mubina Yusuf, stands accused of pressuring her Hindu classmate to convert to Islam and marry a Muslim man.

In Karnataka's Belagavi, a married Dalit woman has accused Rafiq and his wife Kausar of orchestrating a brutal cycle of exploitation and coercion. In Mirzapur, police sealed multiple gym centres after complaints that women were befriended during training sessions, exploited, filmed, and coerced into religious change. In Aligarh, a gym operator, Raza Khan, was booked for trapping and raping a Hindu woman after concealing his true identity.

Similarly, in Noida, a trainer named Haroon, along with associates, was accused of exploiting a widow, recording objectionable videos, and extorting money while allegedly coercing her to change her religion. In Surat, Kausar Ali was arrested for allegedly manipulating a married woman into a live-in relationship under false promises of marriage, accompanied by repeated sexual assault and threats. Recently, in Maharashtra's Amravati, Mohd Ayaz was arrested for allegedly exploiting 180 minors (mostly Hindus) and recording large volumes of explicit material.

In 2025, UP police exposed the conver-

sion network of Jalaluddin alias Chhangur Baba, allegedly involving nearly a thousand operatives. Hindu girls, including minors, were reportedly lured through relationships and pushed towards conversion, with fixed monetary incentives. With foreign funding of around ₹500 crore under scrutiny, the case points to a structured, well-funded network.

The 1992 Ajmer serial rape case remains one of the most calculated displays of organised depravity in modern India. Led by Farooq and Nafees Chishti, a predatory syndicate transformed a pilgrimage city into a hunting ground, systematically shattering the lives of hundreds of schoolgirls-some as young as 11.

This was no mere scandal; it was a cold-blooded industry of exploitation where girls were lured through social manipulation, assaulted in isolation, and then weaponised against themselves. By photographing the crimes, the perpetrators used the victims' own trauma as a tool for blackmail, forcing them into a horrific cycle of silence or the unthinkable task of recruiting their own peers to feed the network.

Justice, however, proved as stagnant as the crime was prolific. For 32 years, the survivors lived under the weight of their

trauma while the legal system stalled and political influence shielded the guilty. It took until August 2024 for a POCSO court to finally deliver life sentences to six of the men involved, including Salim Chishti and Iqbal Bhati.

It would, however, be historically inaccurate to assume that concerns surrounding such patterns emerged only in recent decades. Their roots can be traced back to the repeated Islamic invasions and British

India. Gandhiji himself acknowledged the disturbing nature of such incidents.

Speaking in Rawalpindi on February 5, 1925, Gandhiji observed: "Sometimes Muslims kidnap a woman and make her embrace Islam... If someone abducts my wife and she reads the Kalma, then I can no more live in this world. Either I would seek your help [in defending her] or beg you to take her back into the Hindu fold. I would be a coward if I did not act in this manner." Gandhi's words were not rhetorical flourish; they reflected a lived reality that deeply unsettled inter-community relations.

The March 5, 2026 column titled 'Open Letter to Justice Ujjal Bhuyan' examined the controversy surrounding the film 'The Kerala Story 2: Goes Beyond', which brought forward testimonies of women

recounting physical abuse, coercion, and forced consumption of beef after marriage-an act carrying profound civilisational significance for many Hindu women.

Nor is this phenomenon confined to India. The 'grooming gang' scandal in the United Kingdom exposed systematic exploitation of minor girls, including trafficking, repeated assault, and organised abuse. In this scandal, all the convicted men were Muslims. Recently, in London, a 14-year-old Sikh girl was reportedly entrapped, abducted, and assaulted by a 'grooming gang'. These cases underline that the intersection of identity, exploitation, and power is not geographically confined.

In his paper 'Demographic Islamisation: Non-Muslims in Muslim Countries', Philippe Fargues examines how demographic change in Muslim societies has, in part, been shaped by intermarriage. He concludes: "Love was now playing the same role in the continuing process of Islamisation that coercion played in the remote past."

Extending this line of argument, Christian C Sahner, in 'Christian Martyrs under Islam: Religious Violence and the Making of the Muslim World', observes: "Islam spread through the Christian world via the bedroom."

Taken together, these perspectives suggest that intermarriage, beyond being a social institution, has been closely linked with processes of religious transmission and, over time, demographic change. However, a segment of India's so-called 'secularists' continues to trivialise or outright deny these patterns, branding any discussion as communal or regressive. This reflexive denial does not promote harmony; it hinders it.

A society that refuses to confront uncomfortable truths condemns itself to perpetual discord. If "secularism" is to retain any credibility, it must rest on intellectual honesty-recognising that communal tensions are not manufactured in a vacuum but are often sustained by denial masquerading as virtue.

All such loathsome characters can be called jihadists, who usually operate underground, out of the public eye. Most self-proclaimed secularists are the overt face of the same sordid phenomenon. It wouldn't be surprising if all these heinous crimes are theorised and ultimately justified by the 'secular pack' on some ideological grounds. Didn't this pack work for and rationalise the partition of the country?

Make in India needs faster signals: What electricity reveals about manufacturing



ASHISH KUMAR

PAYAL SETH

More than a decade after the launch of Make in India, manufacturing remains central to India's growth strategy. The ambition to raise manufacturing's share of GDP from about 15-16% to 25% has been reiterated across policy documents, industrial corridors, and Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes spanning fourteen sectors. Billions in fiscal support and regulatory effort are tied to this goal. Yet a striking irony remains: India continues to measure manufacturing output far too slowly.

The most comprehensive manufacturing dataset, the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI), is released with a lag of 18-24 months. Manufacturing Gross Value Added (GVA) in the National Accounts Statistics (NAS) becomes available about a year after the reference period and undergoes multiple revisions. State-level manufacturing GVA appears with even longer delays. The Index of Industrial Production (IIP), while monthly, is an index with limited coverage, high volatility, and well-known measurement issues.

For an economy aspiring to global manufacturing competitiveness, this constitutes a serious information gap.

At the same time, India already tracks a variable at high frequency, across states and sectors, with minimal reporting error: electricity consumption. The question is no longer whether electricity can proxy manufacturing activity, but whether India is willing to use it systematically.

Why electricity is a meaningful signal

Manufacturing is energy-intensive. Electricity powers machines and assembly lines. Unlike labour or capacity utilisation (difficult to observe directly), electricity use is metered, continuous, and hard to misreport, and is available monthly (often daily) and at fine geographic and sectoral granularity.

This intuition is supported by international evidence. During the Covid-19 pandemic, European studies using high-frequency electricity market data showed that power demand closely tracked economic contraction and recovery when official output data were delayed.

In China, sector-level electricity consumption mirrored factory shutdowns during lockdowns



and rebounded early during reopening, signalling manufacturing recovery ahead of official statistics. Evidence from developing economies suggests a strong long-run relationship: panel studies for West Africa, including Nigeria, find a statistically significant association between electricity consumption and factory-based industrial output.

What India's own data show

Indian data strongly echo these findings. Over the past fifteen years, all-India manufacturing GVA and electricity consumption move almost in lockstep (correlation = 0.99). This relationship holds across policy regimes, business cycles, and even the pandemic disruption.

Moving from correlation to real-time estimation of manufacturing activity would require an explicit econometric framework. Electricity consumption from industrial feeders and high-tension manufacturing connections, already recorded by state electricity distribution companies (DISCOMs), can be mapped to National Industrial Classification (NIC) industries and aggregated weekly or monthly at the state and sector level.

With appropriate controls for scale, industrial structure, and long-run trends, an econometric model can be developed that can generate early signals of manufacturing activity well before official GVA estimates are released.

Where structure matters

The relationship also holds below the national level. For instance, Gujarat, a high manufacturing-led economy with relatively reliable power supply and dense industrial clusters, represents a textbook case for electricity-based monitoring, with correlations close to 0.96.

The relationship is particularly strong (around 0.9) in other manufacturing-led economies such as Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Uttar Pradesh.

Where correlations weaken, the reasons are structural rather than statistical. Delhi's economy is services-dominated; smaller UTs and tourism-dependent regions have limited industrial bases.

This heterogeneity is informative: electricity works best as a monitoring tool where manufacturing is economically significant.

Sectoral evidence: where electricity works best

Sector-level analysis provides the strongest validation. Food processing is employment-intensive, closely linked to agriculture, and central to inflation management and exports. In this sector, electricity consumption tracks manufacturing output almost perfectly over time, including during the post-pandemic recovery. Under Make in India, the PLI scheme allocates ₹10,900 crore to food processing to modernise capacity and boost output in ready-to-eat foods, processed fruits and vegetables, marine products, and more-precisely the segments where electricity data can provide nimble monitoring. For an agenda that prioritises jobs and value addition, this is a powerful insight.

By contrast, electricity performs poorly in activities such as repair and installation services or certain petroleum-related industries, where output is price-driven or service-like.

What should change

Using electricity data as a real-time proxy for manufacturing activity will require a coordinated institutional effort. MoSPI should anchor this process by constituting an expert group to design the measurement framework, including data architecture and indicator protocols. This effort must involve the Central Electricity Authority (CEA) and state DISCOMs, which already collect detailed consumption data but maintain databases not designed for statistical integration. Standardised instructions from the CEA to DISCOMs would enable systematic mapping of granular power data to industrial activity (by NIC code) and comparability across states. Additional support is needed for states to link electricity connection data with administrative factory records maintained by the Chief Inspector of Factories. Over time, these linkages could strengthen the ASI sampling frame, improving coverage of smaller and underrepresented units, especially MSMEs.

The future

The transition to cleaner energy and rising efficiency will alter electricity intensity over time. Yet, even with efficiency gains, electricity demand continues to track industrial cycles. Direction and timing often matter more than levels. Make in India is about factories, jobs, and competitiveness. Measuring manufacturing output two years after the fact is a luxury India can no longer afford.

Ashish Kumar is President of the Center of Data for Economic Decision-making and Chief Statistician at Pahle India Foundation; Former Director General, MOSPI. Payal Seth is Head of CoDED and Lead Economist at Pahle India Foundation

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KARUNA GOPAL

Sonia Gandhi's recent article on delimitation is topical and worthy of reading, but those who have followed governance under the UPA and NDA closely would be tempted to call it a 'tissue of lies'-flawed in content yet presented convincingly.

The article clarifies that there is no disagreement on women's reservation, but the fact that it is linked to delimitation seems to have irked the author. It is common knowledge that delimitation is a constitutional necessity and is not something that any political party can play with; moreover, it was long overdue. With the passage of the Women's Reservation Bill, integrating both into the same exercise is the most logical step any government should take.

Madam Sonia Gandhi called the upcoming special session an act of 'bulldozing' by the Prime Minister and questioned the 'tearing hurry' for such a session. Clearly, she seems to have forgotten that the UPA not only delayed women's reservation by a few decades, but when it was finally passed in 2023, Rahul Gandhi demanded implementation "today" within hours of the Bill's passage, and the Leader of the Opposition, Mallikarjun Kharge, forcefully demanded that the reservation Bill be implemented from the 2024 elections itself-is that not tearing hurry?

For the common man, all this must be very confusing. Congress delayed for decades what women had been demanding for decades-it is common knowledge that the Reservation Bill was first introduced 30 years ago. They had 27 years to consult among themselves and with anyone they wanted. The Women's Reservation Bill first came in 1996. The UPA held power for a full decade, from 2004 to 2014.

The Rajya Sabha passed it in 2010. For four consecutive years-2010, 2011, 2012, and 2013-the Bill was never introduced in the Lok Sabha. Smt Sonia Gandhi was Chairperson of the UPA; she had the majority and the mandate, yet nothing happened. The "tearing hurry" on the special Parliament session that Smt Gandhi is complaining about now is exactly the urgency Congress demanded back in 2023. So why mislead the country with a false narrative when the NDA is trying to do what the Constitution mandates, and that too in an efficient manner?

The fear expressed by the Congress leader in her article on delimitation is nothing but 'political polemics in plain sight'. PM Modi is action-oriented and does not believe in delay. As the delimitation exercise is linked to the census cycle, which was delayed due to the COVID onslaught, PM Narendra Modi reassured the country that the census will indeed be conducted and that his government has not abandoned the process. As far as her fear of imbalance of power among states is concerned, PM Modi has already assured legal protection for states that have controlled their populations. Delimitation is a constitutional requirement and, having been delayed for five decades, is crucial for fair and proportional representation.

As far as the data is concerned, the government is using the 2011 Census data-the last completed and verified census-as the basis for delimitation. This ensures that states which have responsibly controlled their populations are not penalised, while others that failed to do so are not rewarded with disproportionate representation.

Madam Sonia Gandhi, in her piece, said that the Prime Minister is resisting a 'caste census' and quoted the examples of caste census exercises carried out by Bihar and Telangana. I wish to throw some light on the same. The Telangana 2025 caste survey was severely criticised for alleged manipulation and low accuracy. The survey reports a population increase of only around 2 lakh in 10 years, which contradicts official records of over 14 lakh births and 13 lakh marriages. Naturally, there were doubts about the data's credibility. The survey had the BC population share pegged at 51 per cent in 2014, but that dropped to 46 per cent in the 2024-25 survey, so allegations of deliberate undercounting were not ruled out. Critics also claim nearly 16 lakh people were unaccounted for

and that many households were not covered. So why bring that up as an example, Madam Sonia?

The NDA is not avoiding discussion; it is actively seeking it. The government has called for a special session of Parliament precisely to do that democratically-Congress should seize the opportunity to debate, deliberate, and decide on this issue. For decades, issues of women's reservation and delimitation have been stuck in endless debate without action. What the country needs is decisive action, especially after experiencing game-changing reforms like digital infrastructure and the geopolitical stature the country enjoys today.

The fundamental question is: what does Congress want? Do they want the NDA to follow in their footsteps and go for piecemeal reform? The NDA, which is committed to long-term solutions, will aim for concrete structural reforms addressing systemic issues. Congress will have to stop trying to put brakes on a system that is already running on high-octane fuel.

The writer is BJP National In-charge for Women Policies and Research, an internationally acclaimed thought leader and futurist, and has served on the Board of Engineers India Ltd

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LOOKING WEST



Over the past few weeks, a strange unnoticed trend has beset the Indian stock markets. More so than before, although this was partly true in the past, Indian equities are moved by the previous night's movements in the US markets. If the American indices go up while the Indian markets are closed, and investors are asleep, there is a leap forward in the morning, as excitement grips the buying. If the American markets are subdued, or lower, there is a selling wave in India. Rather than look at the Indian scenario, Indians take cues from the West. This seems logical because the US markets are more tuned in to the nuances of the Iran war, which was initiated by Donald Trump, and which can be stopped by him. Hence, how the American investors view the changes, and developments, becomes critical for the others. If the US shows optimism, something good and tasty is cooking. If it shows signs of weaknesses, the food on the table is stale. In essence, we are constantly looking towards the west, beyond West Asia.

Obviously, in retrospect, more factors are added to explain the movement of the Indian indices. For example, yesterday, the Sensex, or the Bombay Stock Exchange index, was up by more than 1,250 points. According to a media report, "In the previous session, both the US and European markets had closed firmly higher. The tech-heavy Nasdaq Composite advanced nearly two per cent, and the S&P 500 rose more than one per cent. In Europe, Germany's DAX and France's CAC 40 each gained over one per cent, while the UK's FTSE 100 ended with modest gains." Amid the optimistic diplomatic scenario, with another round of war-ending talks in Pakistan on the anvil, Japan rose more than one per cent, and neared its late-February peak, South Korea surged three per cent, and Hong Kong was up one per cent. Even China was modestly up. The foreign cues, especially from the west, were positive for India, which were coupled with those from the east. Hence, as foreigners exit, Indians do not look at them but their markets.

Oil invariably plays a role. In effect, it is the bell-weather price that drives the stock markets across the globe. If it goes up, the indices dive down. If oil settles or comes down, stocks zoom. Thus, when oil was over \$100 a barrel, equities nosedived. Now that the prices are below \$100, and for two days in a row in the high \$90s, investors see many positives. In the end, oil will determine the fate of most economies and, hence, the stock markets, and other asset prices. If it remains over \$100, global growth will plunge, inflation will rise, as will interest rates, and currencies and real estate will take a beating. If the dollar remains high, bullion, including gold, will be depressed. If oil comes down to \$90, or better mid \$80s, the shock on the economies will be muted. If the peace talks progress, and near a cease-fire, and oil settles at \$70, the stock markets and other assets will skyrocket. In the past few weeks, oil, instead of oscillating due to the war news, is fluctuating based on the nature of the peace talks, and peace-related statements.

Of course, what happens to national currencies matters. In the case of the rupee, this seems disconnected slightly with war and peace, especially in the past week or so. Strict measures by the central banks, seen as stringent by experts, have almost stopped short selling, and short positions. Forced to wind up the positions, the speculators, and even genuine banks took a beating, which pushed the rupee up. In the past few days, the rupee has weakened a bit, after gaining hugely in strength, but this is logical. The rupee is being strongly protected by the central bank despite its public claims that it has no support level in mind. Indeed, many feel that the support level is around ₹93, with a desire to not let it go beyond ₹95. The idea is to safeguard the Rs 100 mark at any cost, whether it implies reforms or no reforms, temporary or permanent. Criticism is acceptable, but the fall of the rupee. The stronger rupee provides fuel to the stock-buying pressure.

An analyst told a newspaper, "Hopes of resumption of US-Iran talks, Israel-Lebanon talks, and crash in Brent crude by \$10 in two days augur well for the market in the near-term. The resilience of markets worldwide, despite the IMF's warning about a global recession if the conflict prolongs, is an indication that the market is discounting an end to the conflict soon." Other experts think that the large caps in India may go up this week but face pressure later. The trends will depend on the factors like the sale by the foreign investors. If the South Korean and Taiwanese markets continue to perform well, as they did in the recent past, money will move out of India to these emerging markets. Large caps will take a huge hit. In such a scenario, as was witnessed during the falling indices in March and April, the real gainers may surprisingly be the anti-heroes, small-caps and midcaps.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | APRIL 16, 2026



BUSINESS10

Conglomerate breakthrough 3.0

Diverse business groups are back with multiple verticals

There was a time, until the 1980s, when conglomerates with unrelated interests thrived. This was the era of MNCs. Although they never vanished, the 1990s and 2000s were driven by an insatiable urge to find core competence. Thanks to reforms across the globe, including those in the US and Europe, empires shed interests to refocus themselves. Specific verticals and horizontals were in fashion. But as new areas opened, and sunrise sectors came into vogue, a silent revolution ensued to bring back the era of conglomerates, albeit in new forms, structures, and systems. In a recent article, the two authors at McKinsey looked at some Asian examples, and dubbed it Conglomerates 3.0 (C-3.0).

Unlike the unrelated-business MNCs and large corporations, C-3.0 builds multiple verticals, i.e., integrations within sectors. While these are unlinked, they use the same management ecosystem to connect and bind them together via shared digital assets "such as identity, payments, data, and loyalty." In effect, unlike the MNCs of yesteryears, the new ones move beyond the efforts to pool capital, brands, and expertise. In the case of India, we can look at two sprawling empires, one of which successfully morphed into C-3.0, and another which, though equally successful, struggles to find conglomerate glue.

In the 1990s, the Reliance Group (now split into two) was lauded for vertical integration in oil, gas, petrochemicals, downstream, and finished products. From oil to textiles, or oil to plastics via petrochemicals. But when it launched a takeover attempt on L&T, the patriarch was asked the reason to walk into an unrelated engineering-construction arena. Dhirubhai Ambani's reply was apt for the time. He said that the management expertise the group had to build large refineries and petrochemical plants would help it manage L&T more efficiently, unlock value, and reap the benefits of synergy.

By the late 2010s and 2020s, with vertical inte-

gration intact, Reliance Group, managed by Mukesh Ambani, built several verticals, or "multifaceted ecosystems across telecom, content, commerce, payments, and offline retail." The bind was not just the brand, capital, and management but the digital-driven environment and assets that "enable cross-vertical bundling, and personalised loyalty." In the past decade, it nearly doubled its annual revenues to more than \$100 billion, and its overall profits zoomed, despite huge capital costs. This year, it may launch the largest IPO (Initial Public Offering) in the country.

When he took over the reins at the salt-to-software Tata Group, although software was not visible then, in 1991, Ratan Tata was obsessed with core competence. He tried hard to refocus the empire, and reduce the number of firms from the hundreds to a manageable number, and number of brands from the thousands to hundreds. It worked up to a point, although the group remained diverse, with businesses such as auto, steel, software, and chemicals remaining the strongpoints, even as its entry, mergers and takeovers in auto, steel, and telecom failed.

Towards the end of his career, Tata was criticised for the flops, as is the case with his successor, N Chandrasekaran, who faces the heat under a new Tata, Noel, for the failures in aviation, and others. Unlike Reliance, Tata used the 1980s-based connections to manage a mega empire, which included access to capital, brand, talent, and customer loyalty. Like the Ambani clan, Ratan Tata spotted opportunities in the sunrise sectors like telecom, retail, and software, but was unable to scale up, and combine them into a linked whole. The Tata Group had the expertise in tech, but somehow failed to move on to the next step, digital.

According to the McKinsey article, there is another Asian example of breakthrough success.

"Ping An exemplifies this model by making cross-selling a systemic part of how it does business. The company tracks and reports customer contracts within its ecosystem, which spans financial services, healthcare, auto services, and smart-city solutions, all integrated through a unified identity and data platform. A quarter of retail customers hold four or more contracts," explains the article. With more than 55,000 patents, the group enhances AI and digital skills and tools to allow customers to move seamlessly across the services. It has nearly 250 million customers, with over 70 per cent retention.

Education to build a knowledge sub-economy, or business empire is another feature of some of Asian breakthrough successes. The McKinsey article mentions two Indian firms. Zerodha became the largest stock broker in 2019, and has 16 million customers now, because of the growth engine, Varsity, a comprehensive, free, ad-free educational platform. Through self-education in stock markets and investing, the firm wooed high-value customers, even as Indians desired financial security. Groww came in later as a strong competitor, and "overtook Zerodha as the market leader for active retail clients."

The model was similar: Reliance on education and transparent tools to let customers find it organically.

Some firms, including Indians, use digital and tech to become experts in micro-production, which matches demand and supply at an astonishing pace for the customers. "India's ONDC demonstrates how digital infrastructure enables micro-producers to scale nationally. The company's monthly transactions increased threefold within a year of its launch, rising from about five million in 2022 to 15 million in 2023. With more than 7,00,000 sellers, ONDC shows how local artisans, home businesses, and small retailers can access national demand through shared identity, payments, and logistic rails," explains the article. Others in Asia offer small-batch products at unit costs.

However, a bunch of Indian business empires, the most prominent being the Adani Group, may use multiple strategies to develop multi-layer breakthrough business models. Across some firms, they use digital and tech to create linked and scalable ecosystems like Reliance, and emerge as C-3.0s. Across others, they use the knowledge economy to hook customers. In some areas, they leverage the old MNC-linked ingredients like capital, management, external influence, and valuations. They grab the best from anywhere and everywhere and, in the process, may create a new set of conglomerates, C-4.0.

Such business groups may not be restricted by a specific strategy or synergy. They may opt for multiple ones, which may seem confusing, even random. One can see the business tentacles, coal and power, ports and airports, highways and roads, and telecom and retail. In other words, wherever there is potential, and wherever their clout, and influence may allow them to be. They may be everything at the same time, sometimes you may see it, and other times you may not.

A Contrarian Investor

Debt fund outflows surge in March

It is not the sentiments but a matter of quarterly redemptions

Wealth, said, "March typically witnesses a surge in outflows due to higher redemptions, particularly from the debt mutual funds, as firms redeem money from the liquid funds to meet year-end commitments. However, these are invariably temporary monthly blips, and industry is likely to witness a surge in inflows in the coming months backed by India's strong macroeconomic fundamentals." In addition, the current valuations of the domestic equities look quite favourable. The outflows, as mentioned before, were heavily concentrated in liquid, overnight, and short-term categories, which highlight the role of institutions and treasury flows.

Nehal Meshram, senior analyst, Morningstar Investment, explained, "Debt mutual funds saw a sharp pullback in March 2026, with outflows across nearly all major categories. Open-ended income/debt-oriented schemes recorded a net outflow... marking a steep reversal from the relatively healthier flows seen in January and February (2026). The pressure was concentrated in short-term and treasury-oriented categories, which suggests quarter-end institutional and corporate liq-

uidity adjustments were a key driver. The sharp reversal in debt fund flows in March was driven largely by heavy redemptions. Liquid Funds saw the biggest outflows at ₹1,34,988 crore, followed by Overnight Funds at ₹40,228 crore, Money Market Funds at ₹29,207 crore, and Low Duration Funds at ₹25,227 crore."

The large-scale debt outflows had a significant impact on the mutual fund industry flows and assets. The net outflows pushed the total assets under management by over 10 per cent sequentially to ₹73.73 lakh crore. Sanjay Agarwal, Senior Director, CareEdge Ratings, noted, "Debt mutual funds... outflows were largely the result of quarter-end institutional, and treasury-related adjustments, particularly within liquid and short-term fund categories, rather than a fundamental shift in investor sentiment. Overall, the data highlights a divergence in equity funds continues to strengthen, while large institutional redemptions from debt funds weighed heavily on aggregate industry flows."

Beyond the quarterly, seasonal, and timely factors, debt funds have grappled with struc-

tural challenges, including the changes in taxation, and evolving investor preferences. Juzer Gabajiwala, director, Ventura, said, "Debt funds have had a very muted year with collections dropping nearly 84 per cent from last year. Taxation played a pivotal role in the investors mind while looking at debt funds. FY-27 may augur well for the debt funds. Hybrid funds are the only category to have increased net collection in FY-26, where multi assets have been a stellar performer with investors being more conservative, and taking exposure even to gold. Arbitrage funds are taking the brunt due to expectations of lower returns due to increase in STT (transaction) charges."

Despite the outflows, the consensus remains that the data reflects technical factors rather than a lasting shift in investor sentiments. With the new financial year underway, inflows into debt schemes especially liquid and short-term funds are expected to normalise as the institutional money returns to the system. At the same time, improving macro conditions, and evolving interest rate expectations may support a gradual recovery in interest. While the March numbers appear weak on the surface, they reflect predictable year-end dynamics, with underlying demand for debt as an asset class remaining intact.

As a retail investor, do not be worried about the March mayhem. According to a website, if you have invested in debt funds for emergency purposes (like health and old age care), short-term goals, or even to balance a stable portfolio, stick with the investments. Do not panic for this is a seasonal outflow, not structural, and driven by institutions, not retail and small investors like you. However, there is an odd trend that stands out. This pertains to the outflows from corporate bonds, and short-allocation mutual funds. This is not normal or logical.

According to the website, this suggests that there is "some caution among the investors," there is a "preference for liquidity (cash) over slightly-longer lock-ins," there is a "sensitivity about interest rate uncertainty," and interest rates, and how they move, matter. With the central banks holding the rates, but the expectations that they may go up due to inflation, investors have avoided long-term bets.

Stock markets surge over 1% amid US-Iran talks optimism

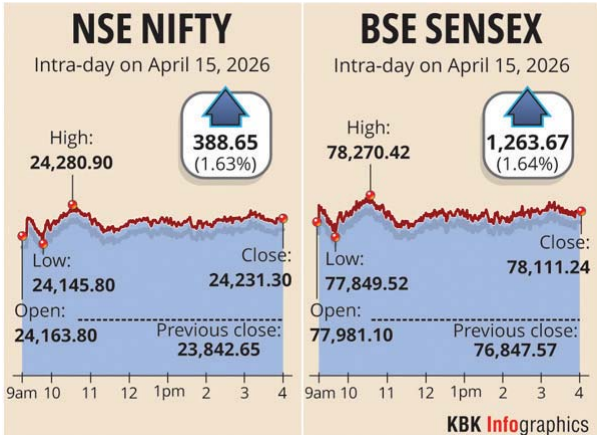
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty surged over 1 per cent on Wednesday as hopes of renewed diplomatic engagement between the US and Iran and crude oil trading below the \$100-a-barrel level bolstered investor sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 1,263.67 points or 1.64 per cent to settle at 78,111.24. During the day, it zoomed 1,422.85 points or 1.85 per cent to 78,270.42.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 388.65 points or 1.63 per cent to end at 24,231.30.

Among the 30-Sensex firms, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal, Power Grid, Tech



Mahindra, Tata Consultancy Services, and Larsen & Toubro were the major gainers.

Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank and Axis Bank were the laggards. Brent crude, the global

oil benchmark, was trading at \$95.74 per barrel, up by 1.4 per cent.

US President Donald Trump has said that the war with Iran is "close to over," assert-

ing that if he pulled up stakes right now, it would take Tehran 20 years to rebuild the country. "I think it's close to over, yeah. I view it as very close to being over," Trump told Fox News in an interview that will be telecast later Wednesday.

As per a US media report on Tuesday, Trump said that a second round of talks with Iran could be held in Islamabad "over the next two days".

The primary trigger for today's rally was a visible de-escalation in geopolitical concerns. Reports indicating a potential easing of tensions in the Middle East, along with renewed hopes around US-Iran dialogue, helped restore risk appetite.

Rupee settles 9 paise lower at 93.44 against US dollar

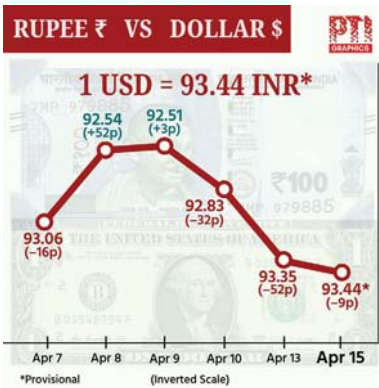
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains to settle 9 paise lower at 93.44 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, as rising crude oil prices after a sharp fall and higher domestic inflation data dampened sentiment.

According to forex analysts, strong buying in domestic equities failed to support the rupee even as it gained initially after US President Donald Trump said that a second round of talks with Iran could be held "over the next two days".

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 93.19 and touched the intraday high of 93.13 against the greenback. It finally settled at the day's lowest level of 93.44 (provisional) against the American currency, registering a fall of 9 paise from the previous closing level.

On Monday, the rupee weakened by 52 paise to settle at 93.35 against the US dollar. The forex market was closed on Tuesday on account of Baba Saheb Ambedkar Jayanti.



Government data released on Wednesday showed that the Wholesale Price Index (WPI)-based inflation rose sharply to an over 3-year high of 3.88 per cent in March, driven by a sharp spike in rates of fuel, power and manufactured items amid the West Asia crisis.

Consumer price index-based retail inflation rose 3.4 per cent in March compared to 3.21 per cent in the preceding month, mainly due to an uptick in certain food items, data released earlier

this week showed. Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst — Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said, "The currency continues to remain highly sensitive to developments around the Strait of Hormuz, which remains a key risk factor for global oil supply. In the near term, the rupee is expected to trade in a range of 93.10-93.65, with direction dependent on further geopolitical developments and oil price movement".

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was marginally higher by 0.05 per cent at 97.95.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 1.50 per cent up at \$96.21 per barrel in futures trade.

On the domestic equity market front, the 30-share Sensex jumped 1,263.67 points, or 1.64 per cent, to settle at 78,111.24, while the Nifty climbed 388.65 points, or 1.63 per cent, to 24,231.30.

Foreign Institutional Investors were net sellers on Monday and offloaded equities worth ₹1,983.18 crore, according to exchange data.

Investors' wealth surges by ₹9.41 lakh crore as stock markets rebound

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Investors' wealth surged by ₹9.41 lakh crore on Wednesday as benchmark indices rebounded sharply amid hopes of renewed diplomatic engagement between the US and Iran.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 1,263.67 points or 1.64 per cent to settle at 78,111.24. During the day, it zoomed 1,422.85 points or 1.85 per cent to 78,270.42.

The market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies jumped by ₹9,41,461.6 crore to ₹4,58,55,016.77 crore (\$4.91



trillion). "Optimism was driven by expectations of renewed US-Iran negotiations, which helped ease concerns around potential oil supply disruptions and triggered a decline in crude

prices. "Market sentiment strengthened further after US President Donald Trump indicated that a second round of discussions could be on the table," according to Bajaj Broking Research.

Infosys ropes Carlos Alcaraz as global brand ambassador

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

IT services company Infosys on Wednesday announced it has signed up seven-time Grand Slam Champion Carlos Alcaraz as its global brand ambassador. Further, Infosys — leveraging Infosys Topaz, an AI-first offering powered by generative and agentic AI technologies — will now work with Alcaraz and his coaching team to develop an AI-powered match analytics and a personalised performance application to aid match preparation and in-game strategy.

Beyond the court, the partnership also extends to joint initiatives between Infosys and the Carlos Alcaraz Foundation, to leverage technology to drive social impact, focusing on tech-for-good initiatives.

Overall, Infosys said, the collaboration is a convergence of excellence — the



relentlessness and grit of a champion combined with the consistency and AI-powered innovation of an enterprise technology leader — celebrating the champion mindset across tennis and global businesses.

India's exports drop 7.44% to \$38.92 b in March amid disruptions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The country's merchandise exports dropped 7.44 per cent to \$38.92 billion in March, according to Government data released on Wednesday.

Imports too dipped by 6.51 per cent to \$59.59 billion last year from \$63.75 billion recorded in the year-ago month, reflecting disruptions

pc to \$860 bn during the 2025-26 financial year.

The country's merchandise exports during April-March 2025-26 went up 1 per cent to \$441.78 billion from \$437.7 billion. Imports also increased to \$774.98 billion during the period from \$721.2 billion in 2024-25.

Services exports are estimated at \$418.31 billion in 2025-26, the commerce secretary said. Due to the war



in major trade routes like the Strait of Hormuz due to the conflict in West Asia.

The country's trade deficit stood at \$20.67 billion during the month under review.

Briefing the media on the trade data, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said that the country's exports are doing well despite challenges. He said the country's exports of goods and services rose 4.22

involving the US, Israel and Iran, which began on February 28, India's exports to the Middle East region fell 57.95 per cent in March, Agrawal said, adding that total imports from that region also declined by 51.64 per cent last month.

The commerce secretary also said that the free trade agreement between India and the UK may come into force next month.

FICCI appoints Anant Swarup as Secretary General



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI), on Wednesday, appointed former bureaucrat Anant Swarup as its Secretary General with immediate effect. According to a press release, his appointment strengthens FICCI's senior leadership, with Jyoti Vij continuing to serve as Director General.

Swarup who served as Director General of Trade Remedies, Government of India, has over three decades of experience in public policy, trade remedies, logistics, regulatory reform, and international negotiations, having served in various leadership positions across the central Government and recently, in the private sector.

A 1992-batch Indian Railway Personnel Service (IRPS) officer, Swarup has served as Additional Secretary in Department of Commerce and Director General of Trade Remedies; Executive Director to the Union Minister of Railways, and First Secretary representing India at the World Trade Organisation (WTO) in Geneva.

Indian team to visit Washington next week for trade talks

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

An official delegation will visit Washington next week to hold trade talks with US authorities, an official source said on Wednesday.

The bilateral meeting between the trade officials of the two countries holds immense importance as India and the US have finalised the framework for an interim trade agreement.

The team will visit the US next week, the source said.

The pact was initially slated for signing in March,



but changes in the tariff landscape following a US Supreme Court ruling have altered the situation.

Official sources have

earlier stated that the agreement will be signed once the new global tariff architecture of America is in place.

VinFast to offer multiple EV options, electric two-wheelers in India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Vietnamese electric car-maker VinFast on Wednesday said it will offer multiple product options addressing different segments in India, including two-wheeler as it reiterates its commitment to the country.

The company, which launched its all-new premium electric, seven-seater multi-purpose vehicle VF MPV 7 priced at ₹24.49 lakh (ex-showroom India), plans to launch two models every year and its electric scooters will debut in India in the second half of this year.

"With the VF MPV 7, we are entering a new segment, but more importantly, we are expanding our commitment to India," VinFast India



CEO Tapan Ghosh said at the launch of the new model.

Noting that the VF MPV 7 is designed for modern Indian customers to move together with family or friends, he said the new model is also a signal of where VinFast is headed in India.

"We are here to offer multiple product options



to Indian customers for their varied mobility needs," Ghosh said.

NHAI asks FASTag issuer banks to validate vehicle registration numbers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

State-owned NHAI on Wednesday said it has issued directions to all FASTag issuer banks to undertake immediate validation of vehicle registration numbers to enhance the accuracy and reliability of data in the electronic toll collection system.

NHAI, in a statement, said the decision follows receipt of complaints regarding instances where the VRN (vehicle registration number) captured by FASTag readers does not match the actual registration number displayed on the vehicle number plate.

Such discrepancies have the potential to undermine enforcement mechanisms and may lead to revenue evasion and also attract other penal provisions under the



Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, it added.

It has been observed that a considerable number of such mismatches are associated with FASTags issued prior to their issuance with the VAHAN database, the statement said.

During that period, validation mechanisms were relatively limited and relied more on manual processes, leading to potential inconsistencies in vehicle identification records, it noted.

NHAI said it has emphasised that ensuring the correctness of VRN mapping with FASTag is of critical importance, especially in view of upcoming technology-driven initiatives such as Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) tolling.

Under the MLFF framework, enforcement actions, including the issuance of electronic notices (e-Notices) to non-compliant vehicles, will significantly depend on accurate and verified vehicle identification data.

"In this context, all FASTag issuer banks have been directed to undertake urgent verification of FASTags issued by them and to blacklist those FASTags that are found to be linked with incorrect or invalid VRNs, in accordance with established Government guidelines," NHAI said.

GOVT LIKELY TO ROLL OUT MOBILE PLI 2.0

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government is likely to roll out production-linked incentives to boost mobile phone exports from the country by May with an outlay of over \$5 billion, about ₹46,000 crore, sources aware of the development said.

The Scheme for Large Scale Electronics Manufacturing (LSEM) was launched in 2020 with the aim to boost domestic manufacturing of mobile phones in the country with an outlay of ₹40,995 crore, or about



\$5.7 billion based on exchange rate at that time. LSEM was commonly known as production-linked incentive scheme (PLI) for mobile phones.

"The PLI 2.0 for mobile phones is in the works with a focus on boosting exports. It should be in place by May. The outlay is expected to be over \$5 billion," a source on condition of anonymity told PTI.

Another source said the Ministry of Electronics and IT is in discussion with the finance minister for the PLI after which it will be placed before cabinet for final approval.

WPI inflation rises on higher fuel prices amid West Asia crisis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Wholesale price inflation rose sharply to an over 3-year high of 3.88 per cent in March, driven by a sharp spike in rates of fuel, power and manufactured items amid the West Asia crisis.

Government data released on Wednesday showed that the Wholesale Price Index (WPI)-based inflation rose for the fifth straight month in March as core inflation accelerated, amid softening of primary food items. As higher energy prices eventually generalise to other commodity prices, we expect WPI inflation to rise further in the coming months.

The high WPI inflation in March reflects elevated global commodity prices and the

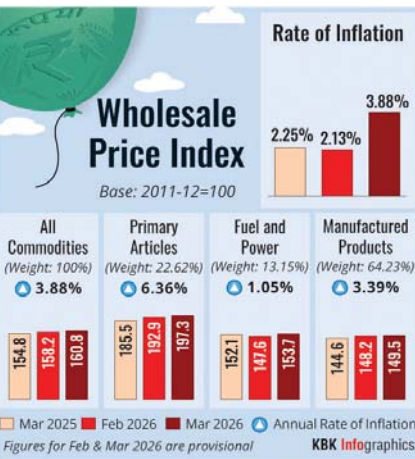
impact of the energy price shock since the beginning of the US-Israel-Iran conflict on February 28.

WPI inflation was 2.13 per cent in February, and 2.25 per cent in March last year.

"Positive rate of inflation in March 2026 is primarily due to increase in prices of crude petroleum & natural gas, other manufacturing, non-food articles, manufacture of basic metals and food articles, etc.," the industry ministry said in a statement.

According to the latest WPI data, inflation in the fuel and power basket spiked to 1.05 per cent in March, from a deflation of 3.78 per cent in February.

Inflation in crude petroleum surged to 51.57 per cent during March, against a



deflation of 1.29 per cent in the previous month. Manufactured products inflation rose to 3.39 per cent in March, from 2.92 per cent in February.

Barclays, in a research note, said that March WPI is the sharpest month-on-month increase seen since August 2023. "As global energy prices stay elevated and eventually trickle to other commodity prices, we expect WPI inflation to rise further going ahead," Barclays said, adding that it expects RBI to persist with a pause in interest rates through 2026.

During March, the pace of hike in food articles prices, however, eased to 1.90 per cent, from 2.19 per cent in February.

In vegetables, inflation softened to 1.45 per cent in March, against 4.73 per cent in February.

WPI inflation in FY26 averaged at 0.7 per cent, lower than the 2.3 per cent average seen in FY25.

Bank of Baroda Economist Sonal Badhan, in a note, said that going forward, if international oil prices remain elevated, then it may impact overall WPI in the coming months.

Global crude oil prices surged to \$122/barrel early in March, driven by the ongoing conflict in West Asia and associated disruptions to global energy supply chains. The prices were hovering around \$75/barrel before the conflict.

"If a peace deal is not reached soon, then a prolonged war can have impact on domestic fuel inflation. Pressure on the rupee may also exert some upward pressure," Badhan said.

FROM THE WORLD

CANADA

PM suspends fuel tax

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney on Tuesday suspended the fuel tax in response to the Iran war in his first act after securing a majority Government. Carney said that with fuel prices increasing sharply, he is suspending the federal fuel excise tax from next Monday until Labor Day, September 7. He called it a “responsible, temporary measure” that also will reduce costs for truckers and businesses.

Carney’s Liberals now have 174 of the 343 seats in the House of Commons and won’t need support from opposition parties to pass legislation after winning three districts that became vacant after last year’s election. Carney’s Government is the first in Canada’s history to switch from a minority to a majority between national elections.

PAKISTAN

Two militants killed in KPK

Two wanted militants were killed in an operation conducted by the Counter Terrorism Department in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan, police said Wednesday. According to an official from the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD), the operation was carried out near the Northern Bypass in the provincial capital Peshawar on the basis of intelligence reports late on Tuesday night. The CTD team laid an ambush in the area, which led to an exchange of fire with the militants. The two militants killed during the encounter were involved in the killing of a CTD constable, police said, adding that the slain constable’s mobile phone was also recovered from their possession. Officials further said that one of the militants was wanted in at least 11 terrorism cases, including incidents that resulted in the killing of five police personnel.

Singapore tells US no forced labour in supply chain

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Singapore

Singapore, largely dependent on migrant workers in labour-intensive industries, on Wednesday told the United States that it does not condone the use of forced labour in supply chains and has a comprehensive framework to enforce against such illegal practices.

In written submissions, the Ministry of Trade and Industry (MTI) responded to two separate probes by the Office of the US Trade Representative on alleged structural excess capacity in manufacturing sectors and the effectiveness of Singapore’s measures to

New Israeli strikes hit Lebanon after Washington talks

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Tyre

Israeli strikes rocked southern Lebanon overnight and into Wednesday, a day after a first round of historic talks between Lebanese and Israeli officials in Washington. Smoke rose over the coastal city of Tyre, underscoring the fragility of diplomatic efforts.

Though Israeli strikes in Beirut have eased since last week’s shattering 10-minute bombardment without warning that killed over 350 people across the country, areas in southern Lebanon remain under frequent attack.

Israel’s military has periodically issued warnings telling residents of wide swathes of southern



Smoke rising following an Israeli airstrike on the village of Qlaileh, as seen from the southern port city of Tyre AP

Lebanon to flee, but thousands have stayed, either because they don’t want to leave their homes or because they have nowhere to go. Tyre was once viewed by many dis-

placed families as a relative refuge from the heaviest fighting in areas closer to the Israeli border.

Now many residents say there is little sense of safety anywhere as Israel targets the

Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group.

Across the city, the aftermath of bombardment was visible in shattered buildings, mounds of rubble and debris-strewn streets. Residents

moved cautiously along roads lined with wreckage.

An Israeli drone struck a car overnight a few hundred meters from Tyre’s city centre. It was not immediately clear who was targeted, but witnesses said it killed a young woman who was sitting outside her house nearby.

Mourners gathered Wednesday to bury the woman, 19-year-old Ghadir Baalbaki, in a temporary cemetery for those killed during the war. Many families are unable to bury relatives in hometowns closer to the front lines. “We prayed maghrib (the Islamic evening prayer) and went and sat outside. We were sitting for 10 minutes before the strike hit

us,” said Mariam Hamoud, Baalbaki’s aunt. “I hugged Ghadir because I thought she had fainted. I kept trying to wake her up.” Her father, Mohammed Baalbaki, stood beside the grave in tears.

“We cannot adapt to life without her,” he said. “Since this tragedy took place yesterday we have been suffering.”

The latest escalation between Israel and Hezbollah began when Hezbollah fired several rockets towards northern Israel, just days after the US and Israel launched their war on Iran. Israel responded with an intense aerial campaign and ground invasion.

More than 2,000 people have been killed in Israeli strikes, Lebanon’s health min-

istry has said, and over one million Lebanese people have been displaced. Tuesday’s talks in Washington marked a rare face-to-face meeting between Lebanese and Israeli officials.

But Hezbollah opposes the talks, viewing it as a concession to the Israelis while they continue to bomb the country. The Lebanese government, which has been critical of Hezbollah for dragging the country into another war, says talks are the only way to end the fighting.

Israel’s military said on Wednesday that it had struck more than 200 Hezbollah targets in southern Lebanon as it presses ahead with its aerial and ground war there despite the US-Iran ceasefire.

UN urges strict checks on Iran in any deal to end war

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Seoul

The head of the UN’s nuclear watchdog said on Wednesday that “very detailed” measures to verify Iran’s nuclear activities must be included in a potential US-Iran agreement to end their war in the West Asia.

International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) Director General Rafael Grossi stressed the need for the thorough verification regime for Iran’s nuclear programme, as US President Donald Trump said on Tuesday that a second round of talks with Iran could happen over the next two days.

The Trump administration has said that preventing Iran from gaining a nuclear weapon is a key war aim. Iran has previously said it isn’t developing such weapons but rejected limits on its nuclear programme.

Last weekend in Pakistan, an initial round of talks between the two coun-



IAEA Director General Rafael Grossi

tries failed to produce an agreement.

The White House said Iran’s nuclear ambitions were a central sticking point. But an Iranian diplomatic official, speaking on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the

closed-door talks, denied that negotiations had failed over Iran’s nuclear ambitions. “Iran has a very ambitious, wide nuclear programme so all of that will require the presence of IAEA inspectors,” Grossi told reporters in Seoul. “Otherwise, you will not have an agreement. You will have an illusion of an agreement.”

He said that any agreement on nuclear technology “requires very detailed verification mechanisms.”

Iran has not allowed the IAEA access to its nuclear facilities bombed by Israel and the United States during a 12-day war in June, according to a confidential IAEA report circulated to member states and seen by The Associated Press in February.

The report stressed that it “cannot verify whether Iran has suspended all enrichment-related activities,” or the “size of Iran’s uranium stockpile at the affected nuclear facilities.”

Russia reiterates readiness to take Iran’s enriched uranium

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

Russia’s top diplomat on Wednesday reiterated that Moscow was ready “to play a role in solving the problem of enriched uranium” in Iran.

“This role can take on many forms, including reprocessing highly enriched uranium into fuel-grade uranium, transferring a certain amount to Russia for storage.

Anything that is acceptable to Iran without, I repeat, violating its inalienable right, like the right of any other state, to enrich uranium for peaceful purposes,” Lavrov told reporters in Beijing, where he is on a two-day



Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov

visit. Russia was part of the 2015 deal between Iran and six nuclear powers offering sanctions relief for Tehran in exchange for curbing its atomic programme and opening it to broader international scrutiny.

As part of the deal, Moscow removed large amounts of enriched uranium from Iran.

The Kremlin offered political support to Iran when the US unilaterally withdrew from the agreement during Trump’s first term.

Efforts to extend ceasefire make progress, officials say. Mediators’ efforts to extend a ceasefire between the United States and Iran have made progress as the warring sides are expected to return soon to the table for another round of negotiations, regional officials said.

The officials said mediators aim to extend the ceasefire, which is due to expire on April 22, for at least another two weeks to allow diplomacy another chance.

Starmer defends UK stance of West Asia conflict

ADITI KHANNA
London

Prime Minister Keir Starmer hit back on Wednesday after President Donald Trump’s latest attack over the UK’s decision not to join the US strikes on Iran, this time threatening to review a trade deal agreed last year.

In a phone call with ‘Sky News’ on Tuesday, the US President said it was “sad” that the so-called special relationship with Britain has been strained despite him agreeing to a “good” trade deal “which can always be changed”. This latest threat was raised in the House of Commons, with Liberal Democrat leader Ed Davey questioning the feasibility of King Charles III’s upcoming



State Visit to the US going ahead against the backdrop of such attacks by Trump.

“My position on the Iran war has been clear from the start. We’re not going to get dragged into this war. It is not our war,” Starmer told Parliament. “A lot of pressure has been applied to me to take a different course, and

that pressure included what happened last night (Trump’s ‘Sky News’ interview). I’m not going to change my mind. I’m not going to yield. It is not in our national interest to join this war, and we will not do so,” he said. He went on to stress that the war would not impact the British monarch’s four-day

visit to the US, which commences on April 27.

“The purpose of the visit is to mark the 250th anniversary of relations and independence of the US. The monarchy is an important reminder of the long-standing bonds and enduring relationship between our two countries, which are far greater than anyone who occupies any particular office at any particular time,” said Starmer.

It came as Buckingham Palace released details of the visit by King Charles and Queen Camilla, which will commemorate the 250th anniversary of the signing of the Declaration of Independence and cover Washington DC, New York and Virginia. (PTI)

New Hungary Govt could take power at beginning of May, says Magyar

JUSTIN SPIKE ■ Budapest

Hungarian opposition leader and election winner Peter Magyar said Wednesday that the country’s president had assured him in a meeting that his new Government could take power in the first week of May, an accelerated timeline for the end of Prime Minister Viktor Orban’s 16-year reign.

Following Magyar and his centre-right Tisza party’s landslide victory in Sunday’s election in which it won a two-thirds parliamentary majority, the opposition leader has pushed for the transfer of power to occur as



quickly as possible. Under Hungarian law, the inaugural session of the new parliament, which must elect a new prime minister, must occur no later than May 12.

Following a private consultation with President Tamas Sulyok on Wednesday, Magyar told reporters outside the presidential palace in Budapest that Sulyok had assured

him that Magyar would be his nominee for the next prime minister, and that the inaugural session would likely be scheduled for the 6th or 7th of May.

“The president thinks, and I think everyone thinks, that it’s in the interests of the Hungarian nation that after such an overwhelming mandate from the voters, a change in Government and a change of regime should happen as quickly as possible,” Magyar said.

Magyar has vowed to conduct a major overhaul of much of Hungary’s Governmental structure, and to create separate ministries for health, environ-

mental protection and education that did not exist under Orban.

In his first appearance on Hungary’s public broadcaster in nearly two years on Wednesday morning, Magyar said his new Government would suspend the service’s news programming—which has functioned for years as a mouthpiece for Orban’s Fidesz party—until “conditions are established that are independent, objective, and impartial.”

“One of the key elements of our program is that this factory of lies will come to an end once the Tisza Government is formed,” he told the host. (AP)

3 Indians named among 100 most influential people by TIME magazine

YOSHITA SINGH
New York

Google CEO Sundar Pichai, Michelin-star chef Vikas Khanna, actor Ranbir Kapoor, YouTube Chief Neal Mohan and New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani have been named among the 100 most influential people in the world by TIME this year.

TIME released its list of the ‘100 Most Influential People of 2026’ Wednesday, a compilation that includes global pioneers, leaders, and titans to artists, innovators, and icons. The list includes global leaders such as US President Donald Trump, Pope Leo XIV, US Secretary of



Sundar Pichai



Vikas Khanna



Ranbir Kapoor

State Marco Rubio, Prime Minister of Canada Mark Carney, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and commander of the 2026 Artemis II Reid Wiseman. Emphasising that honorees on the list are “changing culture in unprecedented ways,” TIME

said “that evolution is inspired by the knowledge that influence comes in many forms, as captured in the 2026 TIME100: a character imagined by novelist Tayari Jones; a meal prepared by chef Vikas Khanna; a moment captured by photographer Lynsey Addario, whose work has been fea-

tured in TIME since the Afghanistan war.”

“We are inspired by the heroics of Olympians on this year’s list, including Alysa Liu, Hilary Knight, and Chloe Kim—as we are by the genius of doctors like Kiran Musunuru and Rebecca Ahrens-Nicklas. Influence, as we often say, has no age requirement. The list includes both 96-year-old Huerta and 35-year-old Balendra Shah, elected Nepal’s Prime Minister following the country’s Gen Z protests,” it added.

On Pichai, the TIME magazine profile said “Few leaders have brought artificial intelligence to more people” than

him. “Since becoming CEO of Google in 2015, he has overseen the translation and implementation of Google’s research breakthroughs into products used by billions.” It added that even though Google is 27 years old, Pichai’s leadership has “emphasized startup-like nimbleness, launching innovative AI products” such as Google AI Studio, Notebook LM, Gemini CLI and Antivagrity.

The TIME profile for Khanna describes him as a “man of extraordinary heart. “His generosity extends far beyond the kitchen, reaching communities across the world with compassion, dignity, and a

deep sense of responsibility. What makes Vikas so unique is his ability to connect with people from every walk of life, using food as a universal language to build bridges and foster understanding.” James Beard Award-winning chef and co-owner of LeBernardin Eric Ripert wrote in the TIME profile for Khanna.

Khanna carries his culture with “immense pride”, sharing the richness of Indian traditions while making them accessible and meaningful to a global audience.

“With Bungalow, he has created more than a restaurant—it is a living expression of storytelling” the profile said. (PTI)



SAGAR KULKARNI
Washington

Immigrants who acquire US citizenship should think of themselves as Americans and not the country where they came from, US Vice President JD Vance said.

Addressing students at the University of Georgia on Tuesday, Vance said he is married to the daughter of Indian immigrants, who have greatly contributed to the US, but his father-in-law never asked him to do anything specifically in the interest of his country of origin.

“When you become an American citizen, whether your family is nine generations of lineage in the United States or whether your family has zero generations of lineage in the United States, one of the responsibilities that we must expect of citizens... is that you have to think about the best interest of the country, and not the country you came from beforehand and not of any sort of any group that you came from,” Vance said in response to a question from a student of Indian-origin.

The student complained of fraud in the H-1B visa system and said her parents were yet to get their Green cards.

“You’ve got to think of yourself as an American. The system only works if everybody thinks of themselves as an American,” the vice president said at the event organised by Turning Point USA, a non-profit organisation that

promotes conservative politics at educational institutions. Vance recalled an incident from his Senate campaign trail where an American of Ukrainian origin asked him to do something to support his country. “Sir, with all due respect, if you’re an American, your country is the United States of America, not a place that you immigrated from whenever that was,” Vance recalled telling the Ukrainian-American.

Vance said his father-in-law moved to the US from India, got educated here and became an American citizen.

“...never once, never once in my life, has he ever said, “You have to do this,” or, “You should do this,” because it’s in the best interest of the country that I came from,” the vice president said.

“I think to the extent that attitude dominates among the new generation of Americans, that makes Americans feel welcoming towards people because to be an American means to look out for Americans first, and that’s the perspective we have to take to our immigration policy,” Vance said. (PTI)

250 missing after boat capsizes in Andaman sea

JULHAS ALAM ■ Dhaka

At least 250 people, including Rohingya refugees and Bangladeshi nationals, were missing after a boat capsized in the Andaman Sea recently on the way to Malaysia, according to the United Nations' refugee and migration agencies.

While details remained sketchy, Bangladesh Coast Guard spokesperson Lt Com Sabbir Alam Suzan told *The Associated Press* on Wednesday that nine people, including three Rohingya and six Bangladeshis, were rescued on April 9.

Suzan said the Bangladesh flag carrier MT Meghna Pride rescued the nine people when the crew found them floating at sea after the capsizing. When the boat sank and the status of any search Wednesday were unclear.

The UN high commissioner for refugees and the International Organisation for Migration in a joint statement said on Tuesday that the trawler departed from Teknaf in the southern Bangladeshi district of Cox's Bazar carrying a large number of passengers to Malaysia.

Overcrowding, strong winds and rough seas caused the vessel to lose control and sink, the agencies said.

Shari Nijman, a UNCHR communication officer in Cox's Bazar, said on Wednesday that the agency



had no other updates. Another coast guard media official told that the rescued people, eight men and one woman, were all safe after being handed over to the coast guard, who brought them to the police in Teknaf.

The official said the rescue was not part of any official search operation as it is outside Bangladesh territory, and that the crew of the MT Meghna Pride saved the people while it was on its way to Indonesia from Bangladesh's Chittagong.

The official spoke by phone on condition of anonymity in line with official policy.

UNHCR and IOM said the disappearance reflected the protracted displacement of Rohingya people and the absence of durable solu-

tions. They said ongoing violence in Myanmar's Rakhine State has made the Rohingya's safe return to Myanmar uncertain, while limited humanitarian assistance, as well as restricted access to education and employment in refugee camps, continue to push vulnerable Rohingya refugees to choose risky sea journeys, often based on false promises of higher wages and better opportunities abroad.

UNHCR and IOM urged the international community to strengthen funding and solidarity to ensure lifesaving assistance for Rohingya refugees in Bangladesh, which has sheltered more than 1 million Rohingya from Myanmar. (PTI)

Xi calls China-Russia ties 'precious' in current international context

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

Chinese President Xi Jinping said on Wednesday that the stability and certainty of China-Russia relations are particularly "precious" in the face of an international landscape intertwined with change and chaos.

During a meeting with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov in Beijing, Xi said the strong vitality and exemplary significance of the friendship treaty between the two countries stand out even more under such a backdrop.

Xi said China and Russia need to use closer and stronger strategic collabora-



tion to defend the legitimate interests of both nations and safeguard the unity of Global South countries, the state broadcaster CCTV reported.

He also called for two countries to showcase the responsibility and commitment of major powers and

permanent members of the UN Security Council, the report said.

"Firmly uphold and practice multilateralism, work together to revitalise the authority and vitality of the United Nations," he was quoted as saying.

"Promote the development of the international order in a more just and reasonable direction."

Xi touted the value of the two nations' ties, but he did not specify what he referred to as chaos and changes in the international context. His remarks came as uncertainty still lingers about how long the Iran war would last.

Sri Lanka repatriates over 230 Iranian sailors

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Over 230 sailors of two Iranian Naval vessels distressed in Sri Lanka after a US submarine attack and engine failure respectively have been repatriated, defence officials said.

A total of 238 sailors were sent back on board a Turkish Airliner late on Tuesday night.

On March 4, Iran's naval ship 'Iris Dena' was attacked by the US killing 84 on board outside Sri Lanka's international waters. As many as 32 others were rescued by Sri Lanka. Then three days later, Iran's

second ship 'Iris Bushehr' was allowed into Sri Lanka waters after it reported an engine failure. Over 200 on board the second ship were accommodated at Welisara, a Naval facility outside Colombo. The 238 repatriated on Tuesday were sailors from both ships, defence officials said.

A group of 'Iris Dena' survivors were accommodated at Koggala, a Sri Lankan Airforce facility near the southern port of Galle. They were receiving treatment at the hospital. On March 14, the Iranian embassy in Sri Lanka repatriated the remains of 84 sailors killed in the US attack on 'Iris Dena'.

Vietnam's new leader meets China's Xi on his first overseas trip



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Wednesday called on Beijing and Hanoi to prioritise advancing infrastructure connectivity and strengthen their collaborations in emerging fields like artificial intelligence and semiconductors during a meeting with Vietnam's newly elected president, the State broadcaster reported.

To Lam's four-day trip to China, which began on Tuesday, is his first overseas trip since he was elected last week. That signalled Lam's foreign policy priorities and stronger ties between the two Communist nations.

CCTV reported that Xi said defending the socialist system and the Communist Party's ruling position is the greatest common strategic interest between the two parties during their meeting.

4 Indian fishermen arrested for alleged poaching in Lanka



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Four Indian fishermen have been arrested, and their trawler seized for allegedly poaching in Sri Lankan waters, the island nation's Navy said on Wednesday. Sri Lanka's North Central Naval Command, in a statement, said it spotted a group of Indian fishing boats engaged in fishing activities in the Sri Lankan waters and deployed personnel to drive them away from the island's waters off Mannar on Monday. "A compliant boarding made by naval personnel resulted in the seizure of the Indian fishing boat and apprehension of four Indian fishermen who continued to engage in illegal fishing in Sri Lankan waters," the statement said. So far this

year, 18 trawlers and 128 Indian fishermen have been arrested for poaching in Sri Lankan waters, according to the Navy. At least 12 Indian fishermen were arrested and their trawler confiscated on April 11. The fishermen issue is a contentious one in the ties between India and Sri Lanka, with Lankan Navy personnel even firing at Indian fishermen in the Palk Strait and seizing their boats in several alleged incidents of illegally entering Sri Lankan territorial waters. The Palk Strait, a narrow strip of water separating Tamil Nadu from Sri Lanka, is a rich fishing ground for fishermen from both countries. Fishermen from both countries are arrested frequently for inadvertently trespassing into each other's waters.

Heavy rains in northwestern Haiti kill 12 people



STEVEN SLOAN ■ Port-Au-Prince

Heavy rains over the past few days in northwestern Haiti have killed at least 12 people, flooded farmland and damaged hundreds of homes, authorities said Tuesday. The rains flooded a local hospital and more than 900 homes. They also destroyed a bridge, dozens of roads and crops in a country where more than half of its nearly 12 million inhabitants face high levels of

acute food insecurity. The rains began on Saturday and continued through Monday, according to a statement from Haiti's Civil Protection Agency. The hardest hit towns include Port-de-Paix, Saint Louis du Nord and Anse-a-Foleur. Local authorities said they are unable to access communities that urgently need food and other basic goods because roads are flooded. The bad weather forced officials in some towns to shutter schools and businesses. (AP)

Student opens fire at Turkish school, 4 killed

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Ankara

A student opened fire randomly at two classrooms at a school in southeast Turkey on Wednesday, killing four people and wounding 20 others, an official said.

Kahramanmaraş provincial Gov Mukerrem Unluer said the student, who was also killed, arrived at the school, armed with guns belonging to his father, a retired police officer father. He was carrying five firearms and seven magazines.

The victims included a teacher and three students, Unluer said. The motive of the attack was not immediately known. Earlier, media reports said authorities sent



police and ambulances to the school in the Kahramanmaraş Onikisubat district, after gunfire was heard there.

Video footage from the scene showed at least two

people being put into ambulances. A day earlier, 16 people, mostly students, were wounded when a former student opened fire at a high school in nearby Sanliurfa province. The 18-

year-old attacker, armed with a shotgun, fired randomly inside a vocational high school in Siverek, Sanliurfa province. He later killed himself with the same shotgun after being "cor-

nered by police," Gov. Hasan Sildak said. The attack left 10 students, four teachers, a canteen employee and a police officer hurt, Sildak said. While most of them were being treated in Siverek, five of the teachers and students were transferred to a hospital in the provincial capital because their conditions were more serious, the governor said.

The motive for the attack remains unclear. School shootings are rare in Turkiye.

The attacker did not have a criminal record, Sildak said. The school had been declared safe, and no permanent police officer was assigned to protect it, he added, calling the shooting an "isolated incident."

Trump backs extending spy programme

DAVID KLEPPER ■ Washington

Congress is set to take up the reauthorisation of a divisive programme that lets US spy agencies pore over foreigners' calls, texts and emails, with supporters like President Donald Trump saying it has saved lives while critics point to longstanding concerns about warrantless surveillance of Americans.

A key provision of the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act (FISA) permits the CIA, National Security Agency, FBI and other agencies to collect and analyse vast amounts of overseas communications without a warrant.

It incidentally sweeps up the conversations of any Americans who interact with those foreigners targeted for surveillance.

The programme expires Monday, and critics want changes, including a requirement for warrants before authorities can access the emails, phone calls or text messages of Americans. They also want limits on the Government's use of internet data brokers, who sell large volumes of personal information gleaned online, offering the



Government what critics say amounts to an end-run around the Constitution.

Despite bipartisan criticism, the chances of significant reforms dropped when Trump announced his support for the programme's renewal, saying it had proven its worth in supplying information vital to recent US actions in Venezuela and Iran. "The fact is, whether you like FISA or not, it is extremely important to our military," Trump said on social media. (AP)

Zelenskyy pursues more arms deals with allies to help check Russia's invasion

HANNA ARHIROVA ■ Kyiv

Ukraine's top diplomatic priority is securing its allies' help to buy and build more air defence systems, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Wednesday between meetings with European leaders, as Russia kept up its deadly attacks on civilians and public infrastructure.

Russian strikes hit more than a half-dozen areas of Ukraine behind the front line from Tuesday to Wednesday, killing an 8-year-old boy in the central Cherkasy region and a woman who was in the kiosk near a bus stop that was hit



in southern Zaporizhzhia, according to Zelenskyy and local officials.

"Every day we need air defence missiles - every day Russia continues its strikes," Zelenskyy said in a post on the Telegram messaging

app. With no plans announced for further US-mediated talks with Russia, Zelenskyy was visiting three European capitals in 48 hours, securing promises of further military and financial support from Germany and Norway ahead of his trip to Italy on Wednesday.

After more than four years of fighting Russia's full-scale invasion, Ukraine possesses battle-tested drone interceptor expertise and has developed ground breaking air defense technology, but it lacks the money to scale up production to levels that would press its advantage.

Zelenskyy said he is asking

European countries to keep adding money to a fund that allows the purchase from the United States of American-made weapons for Ukraine, especially the Patriot air defence system that can stop the Russian cruise and ballistic missiles hitting civilian areas.

Defence leaders from the 50-plus partner nations who regularly gather to coordinate weapons aid for Kyiv were to hold an online meeting on Wednesday, chaired by German Defense Minister Boris Pistorius and British Defense Secretary John Healey. NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte was due to attend. (AP)

Expanding permanent category with veto critical to real reform of UNSC: India

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

India has asserted that any reform of the United Nations Security Council not accompanied by expansion in the permanent category with veto would perpetuate existing imbalance and inequities in the UN organ.

Addressing the Inter-Governmental Negotiations (IGN) meeting on Security Council reforms on Tuesday, India's Permanent Representative to the UN Ambassador Parvathaneni Harish also noted that consideration of a new category, with or without veto, would "complicate" an already existing discussion

that involves wide-ranging views. "There are two fundamental aspects that result in an imbalanced structure and lack of legitimacy and non-representativeness of the UN Security Council — these are the membership; and veto.

"There is broad agreement on the dire need to reform the UN Security Council. It is evident that a structure designed more than 80 years ago does not meet the requirements of the current geo-political realities," Harish said. The Indian envoy recalled that the sole reform of the Council in the 1960s, which expanded only the non-permanent category, led to an increase in the relative



India's Permanent Representative to the UN Ambassador Parvathaneni Harish

power of veto-wielders.

In comparative terms, while the original ratio of permanent members, with veto, to non-permanent members was 5:6, it was amended to 5:10 thereafter

to the relative advantage of veto-wielders.

"Any reform that is not accompanied by an expansion in the permanent category with veto would deteriorate this ratio further and

thereby, perpetuate the existing imbalance and inequities. Therefore, expanding the permanent category with veto is critical to real reform of the Security Council," he said.

Harish also noted that consideration of a new category under the framework of UNSC reform, with or without veto, would "complicate" an already existing discussion that involves wide-ranging views. "It is important to limit the scope of reforms to the existing framework in order to streamline and fast-track the path to reforms," he said. India has been at the forefront of the decades-long efforts calling for reform of the Security Council,

including expansion in both its permanent and non-permanent categories, saying the 15-nation Council, founded in 1945, is not fit for purpose in the 21st Century and does not reflect contemporary geo-political realities. New Delhi has underscored that it rightly deserves a permanent seat at the horse-shoe table.

India also highlighted the issue of the "effective veto" that every Security Council member, elected and non-elected, enjoys on products outcomes such as the Security Council presidential statements, the Press Statements and Sanctions Committees. "There have been instances in the past

where elected members have created hurdles by exercising their effective veto on Council products only to serve their narrow vested interests," he said.

Harish also pointed out to calls for restraining the veto, as he referred to a resolution adopted in the UN General Assembly in 2022 with the aim of convening a formal meeting of the 193-member UN body to hold a debate within 10 days of a permanent UNSC member exercising its veto power.

"However, this has not been an effective deterrent," Harish said, adding that since the adoption of the resolution, 24 vetoes were cast on 20 draft resolutions. (PTI)

BR Ambedkar's legacy honoured at UN HQ special event



YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

The legacy of BR Ambedkar and his ardent advocacy for cultivating constitutional morality was honoured at a special event hosted by the Permanent Mission of India to the UN to commemorate his 135th birth anniversary.

In his welcome remarks at the event held on Tuesday, India's Permanent Representative to the United Nations Ambassador Harish Parvathaneni emphasized that Ambedkar's call for cultivating constitutional morality is especially relevant in these troubled times, characterised by political fragmentation and constant conflicts. It will help strengthen multilateralism, bring about effective reforms in the UN, revitalise its principal organs and make the UN fit for purpose, Parvathaneni said.

The theme of the event at the UN headquarters here was 'Dr BR Ambedkar's Vision of Constitutional Morality and its Relevance for Multilateralism'. (PTI)

PROSPECT



Nagaland BJP President Benjamin Yepthomi attending the PM Booth Samvad Karyakram in Khardaha Assembly Constituency, West Bengal

Railways to run special trains to tackle summer rush

To facilitate the rail passengers and to clear extra rush during summer season, Railways have decided to run special trains, Northern Railway said in a press release.

Train No. 04008 Anand Vihar Terminal – Jogbani Reserved Weekly Special will run every Saturday from April 18 to July 11. Train No. 04007 Jogbani – Anand Vihar Terminal Reserved Weekly Special will run every Sunday from April 19 to July 12.

Train no. 04072 New Delhi to Supaul Junction reserved daily special will run from April 17 to July 15 except 21, 22, 23, 24 and 25th May.

Train no 04071 Supaul Junction to New Delhi reserved daily special will run from April 18 to July 16 except 22, 23, 24, 25 and 26th May.

Assam Rifles commemorates Jallianwala Bagh Remembrance Day in Mizoram

On 13 April 2026, Assam Rifles organised a documentary display to commemorate Jallianwala Bagh Remembrance Day at Serchhip, Mizoram.

The session aimed to educate and sensitise the youth about the historical significance of the Jallianwala Bagh and to instill a sense of patriotism, national pride, and awareness about the sacrifices made by freedom fighters.

The event witnessed the participation of 28 Agniveer Aspirants from Serchhip district who have registered for Agniveer recruitment.

During the session, the documentary highlighted the historical events of the tragedy and emphasised the importance of remembering the sacrifices of martyrs in shaping the nation.

The candidates became enthusiastic and expressed their willingness to actively participate in such events and uphold the values of patriotism and national service.

Assam Rifles reaffirmed its commitment to nurturing patriotic values and spreading historical awareness among the youth through such educational initiatives.



SEBI inks pact with DoT to curb fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Wednesday said it has entered into an agreement with the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) to enable regular sharing of data and information between the two entities to curb fraud in the securities market. The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) comes into force from April 15, the SEBI said in a statement.

SEBI said DoT has developed a Digital Intelligence Platform (DIP), which is a secure framework for real-



time intelligence sharing and coordination among various stakeholders, to combat cybercrime and financial fraud by enabling proactive action against the misuse of telecom resources.

"The MoU will facilitate the sharing of data and information between DoT and SEBI, on a regular basis, for the purpose of fighting fraud in the securities market," SEBI said.

The pact was signed by Sanjeev Sharma, DDG (AI & DIU), DoT and Sandip Pradhan, Whole Time Member, SEBI, in the presence of senior officers from both organisations.

Govt notifies SEZ for Tata semiconductor plant at Dholera



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Wednesday said it has notified a special economic zone to be set up by Tata Semiconductor Manufacturing Pvt Ltd for electronic hardware and software, including IT/ITes, at Dholera in Gujarat.

The company has proposed an investment of ₹91,000 crore to set up India's first chip fabrication unit.

The proposal was approved by the board of approval, the highest body

for SEZ related issues. It is chaired by the commerce secretary.

"The department of commerce on April 9 has notified a special economic zone to be set up by Tata Semiconductor Manufacturing Pvt Ltd exclusively for electronic hardware and software including IT/ITes at Dholera, Gujarat," Additional Secretary in the Commerce Ministry Ajay Bhadoo told reporters here.

The SEZ will be set up on an area of 66.16 hectares. It is expected to generate 21,000 jobs.

To promote the sector, he said, the government last year reduced the minimum contiguous land requirement from 50 hectares to 10 hectares for the semiconductor and electronics component sectors.

So far, five new SEZs for the sectors have been notified. It includes CG Semi (with proposed investment of ₹2,150 crore), Keynes Semicon (₹681 crore), Micron Semiconductor Technology India (₹13,000 crore), and Hubballi Durable Goods Cluster (₹100 crore).

Manohar Lal launches operational guidelines for Urban Challenge Fund

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal on Wednesday launched the Operational Guidelines for the Urban Challenge Fund (UCF) along with the Credit Repayment Guarantee Sub-Scheme (CRGSS) in New Delhi, marking a significant step towards transforming urban infrastructure financing in the country.



Representatives from various States including Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Odisha participated in the event. The Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh, Mohan Yadav, and the Chief Minister of Odisha, Mohan Charan Majhi, addressed the gathering through video messages.

Addressing the gathering, Manohar Lal stated that the Urban Challenge Fund represents a paradigm shift in India's approach to urban development. He emphasised that the Fund is not merely about providing grants but about leveraging public funds to catalyse significantly larger investments and making cities financially robust and investment-ready.

The Minister highlighted that India's cities are emerging as engines of economic growth, innovation and employment generation. Achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047 will depend on how effectively cities are planned, financed and governed. He noted that while initiatives such as AMRUT, Swachh Bharat Mission and Smart Cities Mission have strengthened urban infrastructure, next phase requires cities to become investment-ready and financially sustainable.

The Minister underlined that the Urban Challenge Fund, with a total Central Assistance of ₹1 lakh crore, is designed as a catalytic instrument to mobilise nearly four times the investment through market-based financing. He stated that Central Assistance will be limited to 25 per cent of project cost, while at least 50 per cent of funding will be mobilised through municipal bonds, bank loans and public-

private partnerships, thereby ensuring financial discipline and encouraging private participation.

The Minister further informed that out of the total outlay, ₹90,000 crore has been earmarked for projects, ₹5,000 crore for project preparation and capacity building, and ₹5,000 crore for the Credit Repayment Guarantee Sub-Scheme. The CRGSS will particularly benefit smaller cities, including Tier-II and Tier-III cities and cities in hilly and North-Eastern regions, by enabling them to access market-based financing through credit guarantees.

Manohar Lal emphasised that the Fund will support transformative projects across key sectors such as redevelopment of old city areas and markets, urban mobility and last-mile connectivity, non-motorised transport, water and sanitation infrastructure, and climate-resilient urban development. The focus, he noted, will be on scalable, impactful and bankable projects that can deliver long-term economic and social benefits.

Highlighting the role of Urban Local Bodies (ULBs), the Minister said that cities will be encouraged to strengthen their financial capacity, adopt reforms and actively participate in market-based financing mechanisms. He urged States and ULBs to view the Urban Challenge Fund not just as a scheme but as an opportunity to build globally competitive, resilient and investment-ready cities.

Secretary, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs Srinivas Katikithala, in his remarks, stated that India's urbanisation is entering a

decisive phase. Urban Challenge Fund introduces a market-linked, reform-driven and outcome-oriented framework for urban infrastructure development.

He highlighted that the Fund aligns infrastructure creation with financial sustainability and institutional strengthening, while placing strong emphasis on project bankability and fiscal discipline. He further noted that the success of Urban Challenge Fund will depend on sustained collaboration between the Centre, States and Urban Local Bodies, along with effective implementation of reforms and capacity building initiatives.

An e-directory linking cities with financial institutions, banks and credit rating agencies was also launched on the occasion to facilitate effective implementation of UCF.

The event also witnessed the digital signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and all States, reaffirming a collaborative commitment towards the effective implementation of the Urban Challenge Fund.

In addition, Letters of Intent (LoIs) were digitally signed with key stakeholders, including knowledge partners such as academic and research institutions and capacity building centres, financial institutions comprising banks, NBFCs, international financial institutions, credit rating agencies and merchant bankers, as well as private sector entities. The Urban Challenge Fund will be implemented from FY 2025-26 to FY 2030-31, aiming to transform the cities into new growth hubs and drivers of India's urban future.

DAILY SUDOKU

		3	6				9	8
1	7			4	8		3	5
	8		4		5			
	4						5	
			7		9		6	
6	9		5	2			7	3
3	1				7	2		

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (15.04.26)								
3	5	9	7	4	1	6	8	2
7	2	1	6	5	8	4	3	9
4	6	8	3	2	9	5	1	7
1	8	5	9	7	6	3	2	4
6	3	7	2	1	4	8	9	5
9	4	2	5	8	3	7	6	1
8	1	6	4	9	5	2	7	3
2	9	4	8	3	7	1	5	6
5	7	3	1	6	2	9	4	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
THURSDAY | APRIL 16, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
			9				
10						11	
				12			
13		14				15	16
17					18		
				19			
20	21					22	23
24				25			
			26				
27						28	
				29			
30							31

SOLUTION (15.04.26)			
ACROSS		DOWN	
3. Wheat(-ear)	23. Sea-r	1. He-man	19. Ma-Ll-ard
8. Me-d-al	24. Drilled	2. Jacks-on	20. Carol
10. Rules	26. Oth-E-rs	4. Ha-L-s	21. Big-ht
11. Mac	29. Al-r	5. A-RA-rat	23. Seraphs
12. Clean	31. Litre	6. Tuner (tuna)	24. Dressy
13. Rank-Les	32. Break-up	7. Sedan	25. Lie
15. Rel-a-y	34. Ask-Ed	9. Dan	27. Tithe
18. Say	35. Peg	12. Geysers	28. E-rase
19. Marine	36. Chess	14. Lax (lacks)	30. B-ugle
21. Box seat	37. Shy-I-y	16. Lived	32. Be-an
22. Akin	38. Eying	17. Yearn	33. Key

Military College of Telecommunication Engg wins Army's prestigious award



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lt Gen Praveen Bakshi, VSM, Commandant MCTE received the prestigious Digitisation & Automation Excellence Award from General Upendra Dwivedi, PVSM, AVSM, Chief of the Army Staff (COAS) during ongoing Army Commanders Conference held at New Delhi.

The Digitisation and Automation Competition is

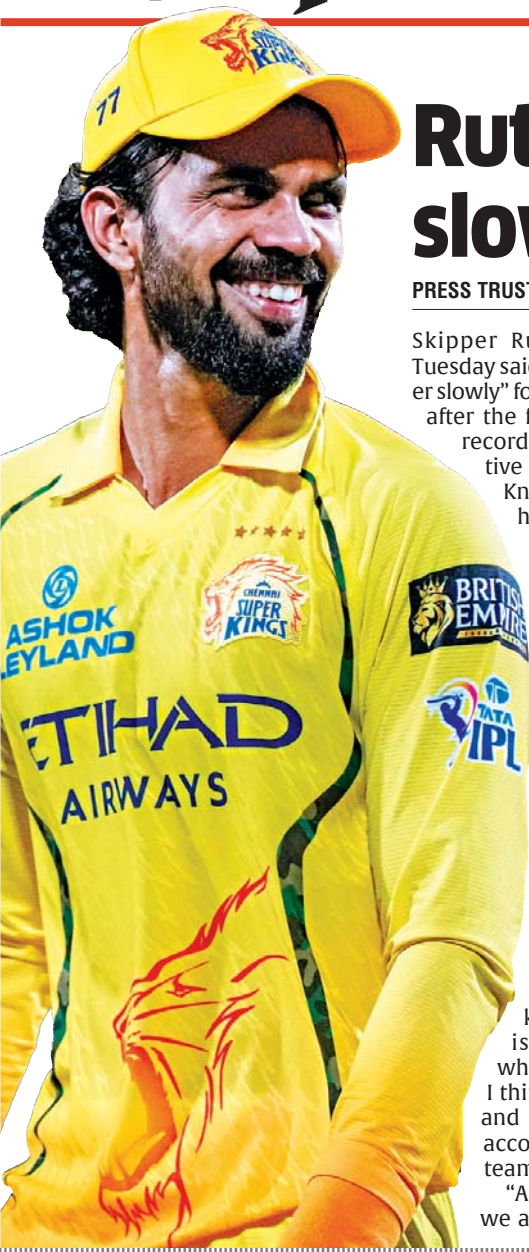
focused on the effective implementation of central applications across the organisation. This initiative aims to further enhance the utilisation of these applications, thereby encouraging the Indian Army to accelerate efforts toward data updation and transition to a paperless, digitised environment.

The ultimate objective is to build a comprehensive and reliable database that can be effectively leveraged to enable

Artificial Intelligence-driven decision support systems, improving operational efficiency and strategic planning.

The achievement highlights the dedication and commitment of MCTE towards shaping the future warriors of modern day warfare. During his address, COAS complimented the awardees and mentioned that their achievement will be a source of inspiration for others to emulate.

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2.	For Verka Mohali Dairy Hiring of cold store for the storage of White Butter.	Annual
3.	For Verka Patiala Dairy Supply, installation & commissioning of variable refrigerant flow (VRF) type Air-conditioning System (cap. ~40 HP).	01 Unit
4.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Supply of Fresh cut Firewood.	500 MT
5.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy a) Supply, installation and commissioning of Dahl and Lassi cold store along with blast room on turn key basis. b) Supply of Rice Husk. c) Backlit glow sign board, non-lit flex board, flex change, A-type standing flex board and vinyl stickers in J&K region.	01 No.
6.	For Cattle Feed Plant, Bhathian (Khanna) e-Auction for By Pass Fat	1000 MT Annual/ 175 MTS
		GKB Annual/ 150 MTS
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2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.		
General Manager (Purchase)		
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Ruturaj Gaikwad: It is coming together slowly for Chennai Super Kings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad on Tuesday said it is “coming together slowly” for Chennai Super Kings after the five-time IPL winners recorded a second consecutive win, beating Kolkata Knight Riders by 32 runs here.

Undergoing a transition, CSK came into this contest after a comprehensive 23-run win over Delhi Capitals and produced another convincing show to beat KKR and move one spot up to eighth in the points table.

“Slowly, slowly, it is starting to come together, I feel,” Gaikwad told broadcaster after the match.

“Everyone kind of knows what their role is, which overs and what lengths to bowl at. I think they are adjusting and adapting really well according to what (the) team needs.

“As I said, slowly, slowly, we are getting better and



better and that is a good sign for us,” he said.

Gaikwad said CSK were aiming for a total in range of 220 but what they eventually put on the board — 192/5 — was also good enough.

“We defended a good score. I felt it was a par score, given that the wicket drastically changed after the first seven or eight overs,” he said.

“It started spinning a bit, it started stopping a bit. We were first looking at 220, 210, but then, we thought anything around 190, 180 would be a good score and

after that, we just had to get a good power play in bowling,” Gaikwad added.

CSK’s win was set up by Noor Ahmad (4-0-21-3), who broke the back of KKR’s chase with a flurry of wickets. The Afghan spinner said it was important to keep his fingers dry in the hot and humid conditions.

“The dew was there, and it was humid, so (I was trying to) keep my fingers dry and that helped me a lot to hit the right areas,” he said.

“I think the ball was not coming really well to the bat and to get

advantage of that, it was good. I will keep putting effort to contribute for my team in the coming matches,” he said.

KKR skipper Ajinkya Rahane said while his bowlers did a commendable job of keeping CSK under 200, their batters just could not get any momentum.

“No real momentum with the bat, absolutely. I thought with the ball we (did) really good, 190 on this wicket was really good, especially (when in) the powerplay they got 70 odd runs,” Rahane said.



RCB’s Romario Shepherd and Tim David after winning the IPL 2026 T20 cricket match against LSG

RCB rides on pace excellence to outclass LSG by five wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Experience of pacers Josh Hazlewood and Bhuvneshwar Kumar found an ally in the youthful exuberance of Rasikh Salam Dar as Royal Challengers Bengaluru outclassed Lucknow Super Giants by five wickets in an IPL match here on Wednesday. A slightly slow Chinnaswamy pitch, much against the pre-match notions, would have been RCB’s bigger concern in the chase of 147.

But once Virat Kohli (49) and skipper Rajat Patidar (27) mastered the deck and the LSG bowlers, the home side scaled down the target in 15.1 overs. Kohli played a typical innings during the chase, striking well over 200 at the start as RCB quickly overcame the early dismissal of Phil Salt.

Kohli, who slammed four fours in a Prince Yadav over, and Devdutt Padikkal added 57 runs for the second wicket and the latter’s contribution was a handsome 10 before getting out. However, the former skipper could not complete yet another IPL fifty as he holed out pacer Avesh Khan to Nicholas Pooran at long-on. But Patidar continued his six-hitting ways — two in a row of Mohammed Shami and one off Prince — as RCB whittle down the target considerably.

Patidar and Jitesh Sharma got out in their effort to finish off the chase in quick time,

but they have already done enough to seal points from this game.

Before batters showed up, RCB gained upper hand over LSG through exceptional spells by Salam (4/24), Bhuvneshwar (3/27) and Hazlewood (1/20).

Hazlewood might have taken only a wicket but his effort with the new ball in the Power Play went a long way to bundle out LSG for a sub-par 146. The night turned out to be even grimmer for the Super Giants as their skipper Rishabh Pant had to retire hurt on zero after a copping a blow on his left elbow by RCB pacer Hazlewood.

However, Pant returned to bat briefly later when his side was struggling at 118 for five after the dismissal of Ayush Badoni in the 16th over. He did not keep the wickets either as Mukul Choudhary did the duty during RCB’s chase.

Hazlewood bowled three overs in the Power Play that read a scarcely believable 3-0-10-1, helping RCB restrict LSG to a way below par 35 for one in the Power Play.

Apart from cutting short a struggling Pant’s tenure brutally, Hazlewood (4-0-20-1) inflicted more pain on LSG by dismissing out for form Pooran, who dragged the pacer on to his stumps.

The lengths of Hazlewood, who returned in place of Jacob Duffy for this match, was so immaculate that none of the LSG batters could find any space to get him away.

Dhoni hand in Noora Ahmad’s match-winning performance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Spinner Noor Ahmad’s match-winning spell against Kolkata Knight Riders followed a lengthy conversation with Chennai Super Kings icon MS Dhoni in the nets.

The left-arm wrist spinner from Afghanistan ended with figures of three for 21 in four overs, accounting for wickets of Ajinkya Rahane, Rinku Singh and Cameron Green in the middle overs to set up CSK’s 32-run win.

Up till Monday night, Noor was yet to make an impact in the ongoing tournament, having taken a solitary wicket in four games.

On a pitch offering little bit of help, Noor was able to get on top of the batters. He got rid of Green with a quicker one into the stumps that the Australia failed to connect.

CSK assistant coach Sridharan Sriram spoke about the work Noor had put heading into the game and the chat with Dhoni, who has not been in action yet this season due to a calf strain.

“I think it was good, the wicket helped today, there was a little bit of boredom for him. The other wickets were quite flat. Today, he was a little bit slower through the air. There was more



side spin on the ball, and there was more drop. So that’s something he’s been working on. “Even MS had a long chat with him during one of the practice sessions, getting him to bowl more leg break. So I think it was very helpful today and the results were there to show,” said Sriram at the post-match press conference.

Sriram stressed on the importance of getting deviation off the pitch for spinners.

“I think to be able to get some deviation off the surface is very important. I think that is what he’s been working on. Everybody accepts there are going to be

days when the wickets are going to be very flat.

“But still looking to be aggressive, putting revs on the ball and getting the ball to spin will definitely help him a lot, and that’s where you can induce mistakes. Because once you start to get defensive, then the batters are going to get on top of you,” he said.



Abhishek Sharma and Axar Patel added to NADA’s RTP



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India’s T20 World Cup-winning stars Abhishek Sharma and Axar Patel were noticeable additions to the National Anti-Doping Agency’s (NADA) Registered Testing Pool, which was dominated by athletics, for the second quarter of the ongoing year.

Abhishek and Axar have replaced Smriti Mandhana and Shreyas Iyer in the latest list of 348 sportspersons in the RTP who will be required to share their whereabouts with the anti-doping agency and be available for testing in a specified window everyday. Three failures to provide whereabouts is considered a doping violation.

The other cricketing names remained unchanged with Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Hardik Pandya, Rishabh Pant, Jasprit Bumrah, K L Rahul Arshdeep Singh and Tilak Verma among those picked.

From the women’s team, which

won a historic ODI World Cup last year, all-rounder Deepti Sharma and Shafali Verma continue to be on the list alongside Renuka Singh Thakur. In all, 14 cricketers have been placed in the list by the NADA.

The athletics count, which was 118 in the previous NADA RTP, rose to 134 now and featured all major names such as steeplechaser Avinash Sable, hurdler Jyothi Yarraji, decathlete Tejaswin Shankar and sprinter Animesh Kujur among others.

Long jumpers Shaali Singh and M Sreesankar and discus thrower Tajinderpal Singh Toor have also been named. There are three archers as well in veteran Deepika Kumari, Rakesh Kumar Archery and celebrated para-archer Sheetal Devi.

From hockey, senior stars Manpreet Singh, skipper Harmanpreet Singh, Amit Rohidas and Hardik Singh are there along with women’s team captain Salima Tete, Savita Punia, and Navneet Kaur.

Mumbai Indians desperate to resurrect IPL campaign against unbeaten PBKS

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

A struggling Mumbai Indians will be desperate to resurrect their Indian Premier League campaign while bracing for Rohit Sharma’s possible absence against a rampant Punjab Kings here on Thursday. Rohit hobbled off the pitch after hurting his hamstring during MI’s previous clash against Royal Challengers Bengaluru here last Sunday.

While it remains to be seen if the former skipper is available for the must-win clash, Mumbai Indians would nevertheless need a collective effort to come out of the mire they are in.

For a squad which promised to have all bases covered before the IPL began, Mumbai Indians have largely had an underwhelming campaign even after they won their tournament opener for the first time in 13 seasons.

Since their most recent loss, MI camp can be trusted to have gone back to the drawing board in order to overcome their powerplay woes which has been one of the biggest factors so far.

Including a rain-truncated game against Rajasthan Royals which had 3.2 overs of powerplay, Mumbai Indians have taken a mere three wickets in the crucial phase of the first six overs in four matches.

Jasprit Bumrah has been spotted on when it comes to containing, but the Indian pace ace has surprisingly gone wicketless in four



matches so far. With a seam bowling attack which also has the experienced Trent Boult and Hardik Pandya, the returns have been minimal.

Even with the bat, MI have not gone full throttle in the power-play where some of the on-song teams have tried to make the most of the field restrictions to give their teams a launching pad.

For Mumbai, the inability to accelerate early on has invariably pushed a chunk of pressure on the middle-order including Suryakumar Yadav and Tilak Varma, who too have largely disappointed.

While the

Indian T20I skipper still has a half-century to show, runs have dried up for Tilak who has notched up scores of 20, 0, 14 and 1 so far.

The unavailability of English all-rounder Will Jacks, who had a successful T20 World

Cup in March, is another issue for Mumbai Indians.

Mumbai Indians would feel it is not the case of lacking requisite personnel but their ability to execute, which has resulted in three losses in a row.

On a benign track against RCB, MI bowlers regularly fed balls to be dispatched into the stands while their batters, owing to an ordinary powerplay, could not press the matter later.

Both the spinners Mayank Markande and Mitchell Santner were punished for missing their lengths on each occasion, but the latter was eventually able to pull things back in control in the following overs.

Like last season, Shreyas Iyer’s Punjab Kings have once again emerged as the team to beat in the competition.

While MI seem to be stuck in the process at the moment, PBKS have been one of the frontrunners, especially in going all out with the bat, enjoying the high of smashing 93/0 in the powerplay in their previous outing against Sunrisers Hyderabad.

Prabhsimran Singh and Priyansh Arya form a dangerous pair, while Iyer’s assuredness along with Cooper Connolly’s arrival has strengthened PBKS further.

On the bowling front, their spearhead Arshdeep Singh has not been at his best, conceding 149 runs off 84 balls in the four games thus far with only a couple of wickets to show for.

Atletico Madrid reaches Champions League semifinals

TALES AZZONI ■ Madrid

Long after the game against Barcelona ended, Atletico Madrid players were back on the field at the Metropolitano stadium to celebrate. They chanted along with the fans, and jumped and danced among themselves.

It was a big night for Atletico. Diego Simeone's team held on after an early charge by Barcelona to make it back to the semifinals of the Champions League for the first time in nearly a decade.

Atletico lost 2-1 but advanced 3-2 on aggregate after having won the first leg 2-0 in Barcelona last week. It will be the team's first last-four appearance in the European competition since 2017. "To play in



a Champions League semifinal, how nice, how nice..." said Simeone, who was visibly moved after the thrilling back-and-forth game. "It's been 14 years and honestly, seeing the team still competing really

moves me," Simeone said. "The players have changed, we've had to start over many times and yet here we are again among the top four in Europe." Simeone has been in charge of the club since late 2011. Atletico, seeking

its first Champions League title, lost in the 2017 semifinals to Real Madrid. It also lost to Madrid in both finals it played against the city rival in the Champions League, in 2014 and 2016.

Barcelona, trying to return to the last four for the second season in a row, scored twice in the first 24 minutes to even the series, with Lamine Yamal and Ferran Torres finding the net. Atletico struck back still in the first half with a goal by Ademola Lookman. The Catalan club played a man down from the 79th after defender Eric Garcia was shown a red card for fouling Alexander Sorloth to stop a breakaway. "We played a very good match, we gave our lives out there, we tried everything," Barcelona midfielder Frenkie de Jong said. (AP)

Mascherano out as Inter Miami's coach, just months after MLS win

TIM REYNOLDS ■ Miami

Javier Mascherano and Lionel Messi led Inter Miami to the MLS Cup title in December, the latest victory in their long line of successes together. Barely four months later, Mascherano is done with the club. Mascherano is out as Inter Miami's coach, the team announcing that stunning development on Tuesday with the club off to a 3-1-3 start and sitting in third place in MLS' Eastern Conference - but winless in its first two matches at its new stadium.

The team said Mascherano cited personal reasons, much like his predecessor, Gerardo "Tata" Martino, did in November 2024 when he stepped aside in the move that ultimately led to Mascherano joining the club



and reuniting with Messi. Mascherano and Messi were teammates with Barcelona and Argentina's national team. In Mascherano's place is another Argentine with ties to Barcelona - Guillermo Hoyos, who is credited, at least on some level, with

discovering Messi at the Spanish club's academy and predicting that he could become an all-time great.

"I would like to thank the club for the trust they placed in me, every employee who is part of the organization for the collective effort, but especially the players, who made it possible for us to experience unforgettable moments," Mascherano said in remarks released by the team. Mascherano's entire coaching staff has also left the club, though the team did not reveal any specifics as to why. Mascherano was 27-9-11 in 47 regular-season and playoff matches with Inter Miami. "Javier will forever be part of this club's history. ... We respect his decision and are deeply grateful for everything he contributed," managing owner Jorge Mas said

in comments released by the team. "Wishing him nothing but the very best in his professional and personal future." It is the latest in a line of surprising moves around the club in recent months, including Jordi Alba — another longtime Messi teammate — deciding to leave the final two years of his contract on the table and retire after last season. His retirement announcement came just days after the team held a retirement ceremony for another longtime Messi teammate, Sergio Busquets. And now, Mascherano is out as well. In barely over a year, he not only got the team its first MLS Cup but helped the Herons reach the knockout stage of the Club World Cup, the semifinals of the CONCACAF Champions Cup and the Leagues Cup final. (AP)

Paris Saint-Germain beats Liverpool to reach semis



JAMES ROBSON ■ Liverpool

Paris Saint-Germain's grip on the Champions League trophy remains strong. The defending champion advanced to the semifinals of European club soccer's biggest competition by dumping out six-time winner Liverpool on Tuesday. A 2-0 win at Anfield sealed a 4-0 aggregate victory and moved PSG a step closer to becoming only the second club to retain the trophy in the modern era after all-time king of Europe Real Madrid. "It's difficult to defend the Champions League, we know that," said coach Luis Enrique. "We are here again and we need to make the most of these opportunities."

Ballon d'Or winner Ousmane Dembele scored two second-half goals to kill off Liverpool's fight and book a semifinal clash against either Bayern Munich or Madrid. Also Tuesday, Atletico Madrid advanced to the semifinals after a 3-2 aggregate win over Barcelona. It takes something special to hold onto the Champions League and PSG is a special team. Madrid won a hat trick of titles between 2016-18, but no other team has managed back-to-back wins since the European

Cup was rebranded in 1992. PSG is out to make history after ending its long wait to conquer Europe for the first time last year. It is the second time in as many seasons that the French giant has knocked out Liverpool, which was in search of another famous Champions League comeback and dominated PSG for periods. "It is a real pleasure for me to know that my team is at that level and can play at that level no matter who they are playing against," said Luis Enrique, who is a two-time Champions League-winning coach, having triumphed with Barcelona as well.

"You can see what sort of team we are, what players I've got. We've got confidence and belief. It's wonderful to be living this experience with this team." Dembele's first goal ended Liverpool's hopes — a left-footed shot from the edge of the area in the 72nd minute. His second came at the end of a sweeping move in stoppage time. Dembele had been guilty of wasting chances in the first leg to effectively put the tie to bed and he failed to capitalise on two more first-half opportunities to put the French champion further ahead at Anfield.

England beats Spain again in Women's World Cup qualifier



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

England came out on top again in its latest clash with Spain, winning 1-0 in a Women's World Cup qualifier at Wembley Stadium. Lauren Hemp's third-minute strike settled the game that leaves European champion England top of Group A3 with a 100% record. It was a repeat of last year's Euros final and the World Cup final of 2023 and the latest head-to-head between these giants of the

women's game. England triumphed at the Euros to win back-to-back titles, but it was Spain that was crowned world champion in '23.

England, ranked No. 4 in the world, secured the victory against No.1 Spain through Hemp's goal, which was turned in from an early corner. Spain's Alexia Putellas thought she had cleared the effort but couldn't prevent it from crossing the line. The 2027 Women's World Cup will be staged in Brazil.



Government of Haryana



Nari Shakti Vandan

Act

A Historic Milestone

Towards

Women Empowerment



Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

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